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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

'India cannot execute projects unilaterally'

PM clarifies House body on agreement

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has provided details on how the agreement regarding high impact community development projects signed with India on January 4 will be implemented.

Speaking at the House of Representative's Law, Justice and Human Rights Committee on Wednesday, he clarified how the agreement, which allows India to support projects of up to Rs. 200 million, would be executed.

As per the agreement, India will support projects related to physical and social infrastructure and the projects will be implemented through either government agencies or non-government organisations.

Local governments wishing to obtain Indian support have to forward a proposal to the Ministry of Finance (MoF) through the Ministry of Federal Affairs and General Administration (MoFAGA). Other government bodies can directly apply to the Finance Ministry.

Non-government organisations can only implement the projects with approval from the Social Welfare Council and the Finance Ministry. MoF need not approve any project until it is under the scope of relevant federal ministry.

The Finance Ministry will be the official authority to request the Indian government for assistance.

Similarly, the Prime Minister informed that project implementing organisations would be required to bear 5 per cent of the costs if the project is implemented in a rural municipality. If it is implemented in a municipality, then they have to bear 10 per cent of the total costs. India can cover 100 per cent of the costs for projects not related to physical infrastructure.

For the implementation of any project, a tripartite agreement will be signed between the implementing organisation, Indian embassy in Nepal and MoFAGA.

Meanwhile, during the implementation phase, the project will be monitored by a committee comprising the officials from MoFAGA, concerned local levels and the Indian mission. It

» SEE PAGE 6

PM to visit Uganda to attend NAM meet

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is embarking on a visit to Uganda beginning from January 19 to 20.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Tuesday took the decision to this effect, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said, while making the Cabinet decisions public on Wednesday.

CABINET DECISIONS

According to Minister Sharma, Prime Minister Prachanda will participate in the 19th Conference of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) Member Nations to be held in Uganda's capital Kampala.

Before this, it was decided to form a Nepali delegation under the leadership of Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud for the official meeting on January 17 and 18 and the ministerial meeting of the member states.

The government has extended the term of the probe committee regarding the purchase and sale of Ncell shares till January 29. The committee was formed according to the Cabinet decision on December 7.

Similarly, the Cabinet has decided to transfer Rs. 2 billion amount to the Disaster Management Fund from the amount available in the Prime Minister's Disaster Relief Fund for the earthquake victims in Jajarjkot and other districts.

Minister Sharma said that it has been decided to form a negotiation team headed by the Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Finance to receive USD 100 million in concessional loan assistance from the World Bank.

Similarly, the Cabinet Meeting endorsed the visit of the Minister for Finance Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat to take part in the 10th Vibrant Gujarat Global Summitt-2024 to be held in India from January 9 to 12.

The government has also decided

» SEE PAGE 6



PHOTO: DIL BAHADUR SINGH/TRN

Local men performing traditional Bhuwa Dance at Chaukhutte Bazar, the bordering area of Doti and Achham districts.

Self-declared ascetic Bomjan held with Rs. 33M in cash from Kathmandu

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police made public the details of fugitive Ram Bahadur Bomjan, so-called ascetic, alias Ram Lal Bomjan on Wednesday, following his arrest from Tan Gaun of Budhanilkantha Municipality-6 in the capital Tuesday evening.

In a press conference organised at the Bureau this afternoon, the CIB provided insights into the allegations Bomjan is facing, which include murder, disappearance of his followers, and engaging in sexual assault.

Upon detaining Bomjan, the CIB conducted a thorough search of his residence, resulting in the confiscation of Rs. 33 million.

The Bureau also seized various items, including foreign currencies of 17 countries, 14 mobile phones, laptops, and pen drives. The confiscated foreign currencies are equivalent to Rs. 3.92 million.

Speaking at the press conference, Additional Inspector General and chief of the Bureau Kiran Bajracharya said that the legal proceedings against Bomjan will now advance to the District Court, Sarlahi. AIG Bajracharya said during the investigation, it was found that he had just purchased one Land Cruiser vehicle worth Rs. 50 million and one Toyota Fortuner with registration number Pro. 3-01-024 Cha 6729.

CIB Spokesperson and Superintendent of Police (SP) Nabaraj Adhikari said that Bomjan will be taken to Janakpur by air, and subsequently, a vehicle will be utilised to transport him to Sarlahi.

"While searching for Bomjan, when I entered the house to arrest him at around 19:15 p.m. on Tuesday, he tried to escape by jumping through the window," SP Adhikari said. It was informed in the press conference that the team of the Bureau arrested him while he was running away.

Bomjan has faced accusations of raping a woman residing as a nun in his ashram in Halkhoriya, Bara.

The case, filed by the same victim, is presently under consideration in the District Court, Sarlahi.

Bomjan is facing charges of sexual gratification and child sexual abuse with nuns. An arrest warrant was issued against him by Sarlahi District Court on July 5, 2020.

His permanent residence is stated as Ratanpuri-12, Nijgadh Municipality, Bara. Since the issuance of the arrest warrant, Bomjan had been evading authorities until his recent arrest.

Meanwhile, our Sarlahi correspondent, Janarjan Khatri said that that Bomjan will be presented to the court as soon as he is brought to Sarlahi from Kathmandu. Sarlahi Superintendent of Police Prabin Dhital said that after Bomjan was brought there, he will appear in Sarlahi District Court.

Registrar Sadan Adhikari of Sarlahi District Court said that an arrest warrant has been issued against Bomjan in the case of 'sexual gratification and child sexual exploitation'.

Mother Sumni Bot had filed a complaint at the district police office saying that Bomjan had disappeared her daughter Rita Bot from Bagmati Municipality of Sarlahi. Bomjan also lived in an ashram located at Pattharkot Syangbo Danda, Lalbandi Municipality-12 in Chure area of Sarlahi for a few years.

According to the locals, Bomjan's ashram is now deserted. Sometimes some of the followers are noticed visiting the place. After the arrest warrant was issued against Bomjan, Sarlahi police repeatedly raided the ashram in Pattharkot.



ALL AGENCIES MUST TAKE OWNERSHIP OF SECURITY POLICY: DPM KHADKA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has said that all agencies of the government must take ownership and uphold the national security policy.

DPM Khadka asked the representatives of all the ministries and agencies to provide the details to the Ministry of Defence in writing within one week about the progress made so far and the problems seen in implementation.

Speaking at a progress review function on Integrated Action Plan-2021 of the National Security Policy-2019 in the Ministry of Defence, DPM Khadka said that all ministries of the government, Nepali Army, other security agencies and related stakeholders need to take full ownership and responsibility and fulfil their responsibilities seriously.

DPM Khadka asked the representatives of all the ministries and agencies to provide the details to the Ministry of Defence in writing within one week about the progress made so far and the problems seen in implementation and the issues that need to be addressed in the matters assigned to their respective ministries/agencies in the integrated action plan for the implementation of the National Security Policy, 2019.

In the programme, the representatives of the ministries and agencies

» SEE PAGE 6

Lack of pasture land hits yak herders in Manang

BY YADU PRASAD BHATTA
Manang, Jan. 10



Farmers in Manang are increasingly moving away from their traditional occupations of agriculture and animal husbandry due to a lack of grazing land.

The shortage of grass for their domesticated animals and the growing fear of snow leopards are compounding the challenges faced by the farming community in the region.

With fading profits from traditional businesses, there is a necessity to explore alternative ways. Despite the calendar approaching mid-January, Manang has received minimal snowfall. The absence of snow has hindered the growth of grass, posing a significant threat to the livelihood of farmers in the area.

Suresh Thakali, Chairman of the Manang Yak Chauri Breeding and Conservation Organisation, expressed concerns about the impact of climate change on farmers in the district.

He added that insufficient grazing areas and the heightened fear of snow leopards have contributed to a growing aversion to animal husbandry and farming among the residents of the district.

Yangdu Gurung, a yak herder of Pisang in Ngisyang Rural Municipality-1, said that in previous years, winter brought rain and snow, leading to ample grass growth. However, this year, the absence of snow has left little chance for such growth. "Children have grown disenchanted with agriculture and animal husbandry due to this problem," he added.

Yangchu Khanda Lama, a 60-year-old yak herder from Bhraka in Ngisyang Rural Municipality-5, said that in the past, they used to store dry grass to feed cattle during the winter. However, in recent times, the grass is rare as it has ceased to grow due to insufficient water, making it challenging to store enough for another season.

All farmers in the district, like Gurung and Lama, are anxious about the lack of snowfall. They are concerned about how to feed their animals, as the scarcity of grass and pasture increases the risk of encounters with snow leopards when the animals move around.

Earlier, yak used to graze without herdsmen in pasture. Nowadays, due to the fear of snow leopards, it is impossible to be a herder.

Tshering Lama, another herder, mentioned that the risk of encountering snow leopards has been rising in the area when they take their yaks for grazing.

"I don't know if the number of leopards has increased or if there is less food. The shortage of grass remains the same. Due to the fear of snow leopards, we keep the calves in cages for their safety, but sometimes the mother gets killed, making it challenging to raise the young ones," Lama added.

Minister Sharma opens Telecom's FTTH service in Rukumkot



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that Rukum and Rolpa are the leading districts that sacrificed for the establishment of the republic in Nepal.

Minister Sharma, speaking at a function to virtually inaugurate Nepal Telecom's Fiber to the Home (FTTH) service in Rukumkot on Wednesday, said that the government has prioritised the service of the people in the region as today's political achievements have been achieved by the sacrifices of the people in the years past.

Minister Sharma also thanked Nepal Telecom and the employees and technicians who worked continuously in the work for successfully starting the service in the headquarters of both districts of Rukum East and Rukum West from today after pulling approximately 100 km of optical fiber from Musikot of Salyan to Rukumkot and also congratulated the residents of both districts for getting high-speed internet service from now onwards.

Stating that after the expansion of the Mid-hill Highway, which will be the lifeline of Rukum, the approximately 124 km section covering the territory of this district will be connected to the National Highway, Minister Sharma said.

Minister Sharma recalled that the then government led by PM Prachanda in 2008/09 had launched the Mid-hill Highway as a transformative plan.

"The government's goal is to establish the Mid-hill Highway as an information highway by providing optical fiber to all sections of the Highway, which is one of the national pride projects," Minister Sharma said.

Pointing out that there is still much work to be done in the field of infrastructure as both Rukum East and

» SEE PAGE 6

Minister Mahat invites Indian investors to attend investment summit

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has invited investors from India and other countries to participate in the investment conference to be held on April 28 and 29 this year in Nepal.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat invited the investors while addressing the heads of states, ministers and investors of various countries participating in the Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2024 held in Gujarat, India, according to a press statement issued by his secretariat Wednesday.

He said, "Investment conference is being held in Nepal on April 28 and 29, 2024. I invite investors from other countries along with India through this programme. I hope that your innovative business ideas and investment decisions will open a new milestone for the development of Nepal."

He said that there were great opportunities for investment in energy, tourism, agribusiness and IT in Nepal and informed that there are other potential areas of investment such as health, education, production, construction and transportation, mining, banking and financial services.



PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Saran Mahat inviting the investors addressing the Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2024 in Gujarat, India on Wednesday.

"This global forum for professional networking, knowledge sharing and strategic partnerships to promote sustainable and inclusive growth is now a forum for all.

Appreciating the Vibrant Gujarat concept envisioned by Prime Minister of India Narendra Modi in 2003, he said, "The Vibrant Gujarat development model being followed nationwide has been a source of inspiration for many countries, including Nepal, to manage financial resources and technical knowledge to address the economic, social and environmental challenges of this time."

He said, "Recently, a long-term power trade agreement has been signed between Nepal and India to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity to India for a period of 10 years. This will open a great opportunity for investment in hydropower in Nepal. This will help in achieving the goal of green energy transition not only in Nepal but also in India."

Stating that located between two world economic powers, Nepal has adopted a liberal, market-oriented economic policy since the early 90s and is a member of many international organisations and multilateral agencies, he said that Nepal is implementing trade and investment policies and regulations according to international standards.

FMTCL starts manufacturing and supplies of 'fortified rice'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Food Management and Trading Company Limited (FMTCL) has started the manufacturing and supplies of 'fortified rice' beginning today.

While launching the distribution of the rice here today, Minister for Industry, Commerce, and Supplies, Ramesh Rijal said the entire Nepali citizens will have access to the rice enriched with nutritional values with the aim of realising the sustainable development goals- 2030 by addressing the issue of malnutrition in the country.

As he said, the adding of nutritional values in food and the priority to the locally available foods are the concerns of the government in view of the implementation of the Right relating to food (Article 36) recognised by the Constitution as the fundamental right of the citizens.

It is said the Ministry of Health and Population is set to promote public awareness on the benefits from the consumption of the 'fortified rice'. The Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies shall come up with policy arrangements for the manufacturing and supplies of this rice. It will be made available at a subsidized price.

The criteria for rice production and the regulation of food purity and quality are to be handled by the Department of Food Technology and Quality Control. The government will have technical support from the World Food Programme for the manufacturing and supplies of rice with increased nutritional values.

It is worth noting that despite improvements in the status of nutrition in Nepal lately, the rate of malnutrition to be caused by the deficiency of micronutrients still remains high. According to the Nepal Demographic and Health Survey-2022, 43% of children under five still suffer from anaemia.

Similarly, the survey shows that 34% of women of reproductive age and 39% of adolescent girls are affected by severe anaemic health complications. The study highlights that 25% of children under five experience stunted growth and 19% have low weight issues. Deficiencies of essential micronutrients such as iron, vitamin B12, and folic acid are prevalent among the population of various age groups. Nepal has expressed commitments to minimizing all forms of malnutrition and achieving the SDGs by 2030.

Transporting herbs on foot turning profitable



PHOTO: PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/HUMLA

Mules transporting herbs to Surkhet from Humla.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan. 10

Herbs businesses have started transporting herbs on foot from Humla district as it is cheaper compared to other modes of transport. As the district is not connected to the national road network yet, the air route is the only feasible mode of transport here.

Pema Angju Lama, a herb trader, decided to transport herbs out of Humla on foot this year by using mules. "It costs Rs. 35 per kilogram to bring herbs to Syaltadi from Ward No. 6 of Sarkegad Rural Municipality in Humla. From Syaltadi to Surkhet, it costs Rs. 12 per kilogram," said Lama.

On the other hand, it costs Rs. 60 per kilogram to transport herbs to Surkhet from Humla by air. "Using aeroplanes was the only option for years. Now, there is a cheaper medium. The profit of Rs. 13 a kilogram is a lot," said Lama.

Ram Bahadur Bhandari, chairman of the local Chamber of Commerce and Industries, said transporting herbs by air was always a struggle. "The struggle has now ended as traders have started opting for a different and cheaper mode of transport," Bhandari added.

While the air route is the only mode of advanced transport to Humla, it is often affected by weather. "Forest Office has issued a collection permission for 500 quintals of Jatamasi from Humla district this year. Over 50 herb traders are exporting the herbs with permission from the district," said Bhandari.

Global economy set for weakest half-decade performance in 30 years: WB

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

As the world nears the midpoint of what was intended to be a transformative decade for development, the global economy is set to rack up a sorry record by the end of 2024—the slowest half-decade of GDP growth in 30 years, according to the World Bank's latest Global Economic Prospects report.

By one measure, the global economy is in a better place than it was a year ago: the risk of a global recession has receded, largely because of the strength of the U.S. economy. But mounting geopolitical tensions could create fresh near-term hazards for the world economy.

Meanwhile, the medium-term outlook has darkened for many developing economies amid slowing growth in most major economies, sluggish global trade, and the tightest financial conditions in decades. Global trade growth in 2024 is expected to be only half the average in the decade before the pandemic. Meanwhile, borrowing costs for developing economies—especially those with poor credit ratings—are likely to remain steep with global interest rates stuck at four-decade highs in inflation-adjusted terms.

Global growth is projected to slow for the third year in a row—from 2.6 per cent last year to 2.4 per cent in 2024, almost three-quarters of a percentage point below the average of the 2010s.

Developing economies are projected to grow just 3.9 per cent, more than one percentage point below the average of the previous decade.

After a disappointing performance last year, low-income countries should grow 5.5 per cent, weaker than previously expected.

By the end of 2024, people in about one out of every four developing countries and about 40 per cent of low-income countries will still be poorer than they were on the eve of the COVID pandemic in 2019.

In advanced economies, meanwhile, growth is set to slow to 1.2 per cent this year from 1.5 per cent in 2023.

"Without a major course correction, the 2020s will go down as a decade of wasted opportunity," said Indermit Gill, the World Bank Group's Chief Economist and Senior Vice President. "Near-term growth will remain weak, leaving many developing countries—especially the poorest—stuck in a trap: with paralyzing levels of debt and tenuous access to food for nearly one out of every three people. That would obstruct progress on many global priorities. Opportunities still exist to turn the tide. This report offers a clear way forward: it spells out the transformation that can be achieved if governments act now to accelerate investment and strengthen fiscal policy frameworks."

To tackle climate change and achieve other key global development goals by 2030, developing countries will need to deliver a formidable increase in investment—about $2.4 trillion per year, said the WB.

Without a comprehensive policy package, prospects for such an increase are not bright, read the press statement of the WB.

Per capita investment growth in developing economies between 2023 and 2024 is expected to average only 3.7 per cent, just over half the rate of the previous two decades.

The report offers the first global analysis of what it will take to generate a sustained investment boom, drawing from the experience of 35 advanced economies and 69 developing economies over the past 70 years.

"Investment booms have the potential to transform developing economies and help them speed up the energy transition and achieve a wide variety of development objectives," said Ayhan Kose, the World Bank's Deputy Chief Economist and Director of the Prospects Group.

"To spark such booms, developing economies need to implement comprehensive policy packages to improve fiscal and monetary frameworks, expand cross-border trade and financial flows, improve the investment climate, and strengthen the quality of institutions. That is hard work, but many developing economies have been able to do it before. Doing it again will help mitigate the projected slowdown in potential growth in the rest of this decade."

UK POSTAL WORKERS WRONGLY ACCUSED OF FRAUD TO HAVE THEIR CONVICTIONS

AP
London, Jan.10

Britain's Prime Minister Rishi Sunak said Wednesday he will introduce measures to overturn the convictions of more than 900 post office branch managers who were wrongly accused of theft or fraud because of a faulty computer system.

Sunak said the scandal, which saw hundreds of postmasters falsely convicted of stealing money because Post Office computers wrongly showed that funds were missing from their shops, was "one of the greatest miscarriages of justice in our nation's history."

Of the more than 900 postal branch managers who were convicted of theft or fraud between 1999 and 2015, just 95 have managed to overturn their convictions, Post Office minister Kevin Hollinrake said.

Some were sent to prison, and many were financially ruined after being forced to pay large sums to the state-owned Post Office. Several killed themselves. The real culprit was a defective accounting software package called Horizon, which was supplied by the Japanese technology firm Fujitsu.

Sunak told lawmakers that a new law will be introduced to ensure that those wrongly convicted are "swiftly exonerated and compensated."

The government will also make a new payment of 75,000 pounds ($95,500) each to some postal workers who took group legal action against the Post Office, he added.

"People who worked hard to serve their communities had their lives and their reputations destroyed through absolutely no fault of their own," he said. "We will make sure that the truth comes to light, we right the wrongs of the past and the victims get the justice they deserve."

For years, the state-owned Post Office maintained that data from Horizon was reliable and accused branch managers of dishonesty. Police have opened a fraud investigation into the Post Office, but so far, no one from the company or from Fujitsu has been arrested or faced criminal charges. A public inquiry has been ongoing since 2022.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice for Price bid open

Date of Notice : 11 January 2024

Pursuant to clause 31(4) and (5) of Public Procurement Regulation 2064, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive technical bidder has been selected for further evaluation as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal DOHS decides to open the price bid on **26 January 2024 on 12:00** Hr.

RFB No./IFB No.	Notice Published Date	Successful Bidders Name and Address
DOHS/G/ICB-21/IDA/2080-81 (Procurement of Nitric Oxide Machine)	19 October 2023	**M/S Maxim Incorporation Traders PVT. LTD** Balwatar-04, Kathmandu
DOHS/G/ICB-2/EDCD/2080-81 (Procurement of Rabies Immunoglobulin)	5 October 2023	**M/S Premium Serums and vaccines Pvt. Ltd.** Maharashtra India
		M/S Vins Bioproducts Limited Hyderabad India
DOHS/G/ICB-3.1/EDCD/2080-81 (Procurement of Anti Rabies Vaccine 0.5ml)	5 October 2023	**M/S Hospitec Pharma Pvt. Ltd.** Subidhanagar Kathmandu
		M/S Indian Immunological Limited Hyderabad India
DOHS/G/ICB-3.2/EDCD/2080-81 (Procurement of Anti Rabies Vaccine 1ml)	5 October 2023	**M/S Serum Institute of India** Pune India
		M/S Indian Immunological Limited Hyderabad India
DOHS/G/ICB-14/FWD/2080-81 (Procurement of BCG Vaccine)	19 October 2023	**M/S Serum Institute of India** Pune India
DOHS/G/ICB-15/FWD/2080-81 (Procurement of TD Vaccine)	19 October 2023	**M/S Serum Institute of India** Pune India
		M/S Biological E. Limited Hyderabad India
DOHS/G/ICB-16/FWD/2080-81 (Procurement of MR Vaccine)	19 October 2023	**M/S Serum Institute of India** Pune India
		M/S Biological E. Limited Hyderabad India



Nepalgunj starts crushing undocumented e-rickshaw

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Jan. 10



PHOTO: SIRAJ KHAN/TRN

In a bold move, the Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City has initiated a crackdown on electric rickshaws operating without proper documentation.

In a bold move, the Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City has initiated a crackdown on electric rickshaws operating without proper documentation. Deploying dozers, the city administration has begun the destruction of the undocumented vehicles, marking a significant escalation in their ongoing campaign to manage electric rickshaws.

The initiative, which commenced on November 27, has already seen five e-rickshaws dismantled owing to the absence of necessary documents. Mayor Prashant Bista stated that the destruction followed thorough technical inspections, targeting vehicles with license plate numbers Bhe 1 S 5498, Bhe 1 S 8751, Bhe 1 S 48, Bhe 1 S 1531, and Gavis 02.

Mayor Bista justified the aggressive action, emphasizing the need to eradicate illegal electric rickshaws from the sub-metropolis. He highlighted that ample time had been provided for rickshaw owners to update their documentation, but the failure of some to comply resulted in the initiation of action.

However, this crackdown has not been without controversy. The sub-metropolitan city has faced strong criticism and protests over its decision to destroy the e-rickshaws using heavy machinery. Critics argue that despite the illegal status of the vehicles, alternative options, such as sending them to customs, should have been explored instead of outright destruction.

Mubarak Siddiqui of Nepalgunj 11 deplored the use of dozers, asserting that even if the rickshaws were operating illegally, destroying them in this manner is undemocratic and impacts the livelihoods of the poor. Social leader Shravan Kumar Yadav echoed similar sentiments, emphasizing the illegality of the destruction method when legal procedures and alternatives were available.

The sub-metropolitan city has taken control of 623 e-rickshaws thus far. Of those, 538 rickshaws that complied with the necessary documentation requirements have been released. However, 85 e-rickshaws remain under control, as confirmed by City Police Chief Surya Bogati.

In response to the destruction of their vehicles, electric rickshaw drivers in Nepalgunj have initiated protests. They are demanding compensation for their losses and have surrounded the Nepalgunj Sub-metropolis Office. The sit-in protest, accompanied by slogans, has brought municipal activities to a halt.

As the controversy unfolds, questions arise about the balance between enforcing the law and ensuring a fair and measured response, especially considering the potential socioeconomic impact on the drivers. The clash between regulatory actions and public sentiment underscores the need for a nuanced approach to address both legal compliance and the welfare of those affected by such measures. The coming days will likely witness a delicate balance between regulatory authorities and the concerned citizens, shaping the narrative around the management of electric rickshaws in Nepalgunj.

Out of 920 heritage sites, 774 reconstructed so far

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Temples, shrines and monasteries ravaged by the earthquake across the nation are being reconstructed under the supervision of the Department of Archeology (DoA).

According to the data provided by the DoA, out of the 920 heritage sites and monuments devastated by the 2015 earthquake, reconstruction works on 774 temples were completed by mid-December last year.

In the current fiscal year, reconstruction work of 14 heritage sites has been accomplished.

As per the Planning Division of DoA, the department is yet to launch programmes to expedite the reconstruction work for 28 monuments in the three districts of Kathmandu Valley.

The record of the Planning Division shows that the earthquake had damaged 215 temples and shrines in Kathmandu, 73 in Bhaktapur and 130 in Patan districts.

Among them, the reconstruction of 129 temples and shrines inside the World Heritage Site of Hanumandhoka Durbar Square, Patan Durbar Square, Bhaktapur Durbar Square, Changu Narayan, Pashupatinath, Swayambhu and Bouddhanath has already been completed.

In Bhaktapur, rebuilding works of 25 temples has been completed inside the World Heritage Sites whereas reconstruction of 19 temples is ongoing and six temples is still waiting for their renovation in the district.

Altogether 31 temples were damaged in Bhaktapur World Heritage Site and nine on the Changu Narayan temple premises.

The record of the Planning Division of the DoA shows that of the 41 damaged temples at the Hanumandhoka Durbar Square, reconstruction of 24 temples has been completed, while the reconstruction of 10 temples is ongoing and reconstruction works on 15 is yet to begin in the Kathmandu district.

Likewise, the reconstruction of 11 of the 12 damaged temples in Swoyambhunath has been completed and in the Pashupatinath area, the reconstruction of 46 of the 59 damaged temples has been completed.

In Patan, reconstruction works of 15 shrines has been completed, six is under way and 10 are waiting for reconstruction.

The government has allocated Rs. 850 million to reconstruct the remaining heritage sites in the current fiscal year.

Likewise, the monasteries located in Sindhupalchowk, Nuwakot, Dhading, Rasuwa, Kathmandu and Lalitpur districts are being reconstructed by the DoA.

Among the 215 damaged monasteries, five monasteries have been reconstructed, and the projects to reconstruct 26 damaged monasteries got started in the last fiscal.

DoA has estimated Rs. 5.28 billion for the reconstruction of 215 damaged monasteries.

Pregnant woman rescued by Army in Bajura

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bajura, Jan. 10

A Nepali Army helicopter played a crucial role in the rescue of a 30-year-old pregnant woman, Seema Baduwal, from Badimalika Municipality-6 Kordha in Bajura.

Samita Pun, District Hospital Bajura's superintendent, said that due to complications during pregnancy, specifically the baby being lodged in the uterus and unable to be delivered, the woman was referred to Surkhet for immediate medical attention.

"Baduwal, who initially visited the district hospital for a routine check-up, was airlifted to Surkhet by a Nepali Army helicopter. The urgency arose as the baby's head was overdue, posing a serious threat to the woman's life," added Pun.

Ram Kumar Timilsina, Assistant Chief District Officer of the District Administration Office in Bajura, explained the coordinated efforts that led to the successful rescue mission. Following the hospital's request for helicopter assistance and subsequent communication with the Ministry of Home Affairs, the NA 9 helicopter from the Nepali Army promptly reached Bajura to execute the rescue.

"Upon learning about the complicated condition of the pregnant woman and the necessity to transport her outside the district for childbirth, the rescue operation was conducted using an army helicopter, facilitated by the President's Women's Upliftment Programme," said Timilsina.

This incident follows a previous rescue operation involving 23-year-old Kalpana Rokaya from Himali Rural Municipality-1 Vichchya.

Rokaya, who had given birth, was also evacuated in an army helicopter, showcasing the continued efforts of the District Administration Office, Bajura to ensure prompt and life-saving interventions during childbirth emergencies.

Gulmi District Prison giving inmates work opportunities

BY RAMESH BISHWOKARMA
Gulmi, Jan. 10



PHOTO: RAMESH BISHWOKARMA/TRN

Furniture and fabric manufactured in the Gulmi District Prison by inmates are on sale.

Prisoners in the Gulmi District Prison have been involved with earning opportunities with the support of prison officials. The inmates are mostly involved in furniture-related work.

According to the prison officials, inmates in the district prison have been associated with earning activities for the past 18 years.

"Earlier, prisoners only made local bamboo stools. Now, with the help of their expertise and skills, they are manufacturing different furniture," said Reshami Raj Panthi, jailer and head of the prison.

Moreover, some prisoners also occupy themselves by weaving nylon ropes, preparing Dhaka fabric and chopping bamboo as well.

"Sometimes, the prison feels like a factory filled with skilled workers. Around Rs. 6 to 8 million worth of furniture, stool and fabric are sold from the prison every month," informed the internal administration chief of the prison.

"Workers are given a salary of up to Rs. 15,000 per month and their assistants receive Rs. 8,000 to Rs. 12,000 per month.

There are 118 inmates in the prison with a capacity of only 25 inmates," said Panthi.

Officials informed that every prisoner other than those sick and disabled work in the areas they feel at ease.

Meanwhile, the prison lacks enough space for the prisoners to stay let alone operate an industry. "There is also a lack of drinking water," said Panthi.

Panthi stressed that the step would be supportive in the context of the government's plan to operate an open prison. "Training prisoners to help them learn different skills and providing a platform to utilise them would be beneficial for all," he added.

Power cut at Reliance Mills hampers studies of workers' children

BY SASHIDHAR PARAJULI
Biratnagar, Jan. 10



PHOTO: SASHIDHAR PARAJULI /TRN

Employees of Reliance Spinning Mills in Khanar, Sunsari, protesting as over 250 children remain affected by electricity cutoff in the industry's colony.

Over 250 children residing in the yarn industry colony of Reliance Spinning Mills in Khanar, Sunsari, are currently grappling with educational challenges. The interruption in the education of these children spans three weeks, caused by the cessation of electricity supply.

The closure of Reliance Spinning Mills ensued after the Nepal Electricity Authority severed its power connection, casting darkness over the colony, home to more than 2,500 workers and employees. With the halt in electricity, children are unable to engage in evening and morning study sessions or complete their homework.

Amarlal Yadav, a labourer with two decades of residence in the colony, expressed the dire conditions of the colony. "The colony's situation has become miserable without electricity. Thousands of us workers reside here, facing a scarcity of both water and electricity, adversely affecting our children's education. Attention must be drawn to this issue," he said.

Nearly two thousand individuals inhabit the colony, with over 100 children attending school regularly. Additionally, more than 150 children from the staff colony are impacted, unable to study and practice in the evenings upon returning from school. "We used to carry on as usual, but the deterioration in children's education is evident. They can no longer read at all," added Yadav.

Mahesh Pokharel, the mills' manager, highlighted that despite resolving the recent electricity problem, the significant generators at Reliance Spinning Mills are non-functional, compounded by issues with the older generators due to wear and tear. Although a smaller capacity generator was operational for a few hours, providing water and electricity in the evenings, it was incapable of running continuously.

Following the power line cutoff, colony residents submitted a four-day memorandum to the district administration office, urging for the reconnection of electricity to the colony, even if only for lighting purposes. Labourer Yadav reported that, despite Chief District Officer Jaya Narayan Acharya expressing an intention to initiate the reconnection, it had not yet happened.

Jaya Narayan Acharya, Chief District Officer, acknowledged the educational challenges faced by the labourers' children in the Reliance colony. "Upon learning about the education disruption after the power cut, I directed the authority to reconnect electricity to the colony. The line will be restored as soon as the workers apply to the authority. It is crucial to differentiate between industries and residential colonies, and electricity will be restored upon their request," he said.

The power line was severed by the authority at 6:30 pm on January 6th, citing non-payment of the non-regular fee owed to the Nepal Electricity Authority for utilizing the dedicated and trunk line. Since then, the industry, which employed over four thousand workers, has remained closed.

Language, culture of Kusunda on verge of extinction

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan. 10

The language and culture of the endangered Kusunda community are on the verge of extinction. The death of senior citizens and the lack of knowledge transfer to the younger generation has put the community's linguistic and social traditions in crisis.

Indra Maya Tamang, a resident of Dihigaun, Vyas Municipality-10, told The Rising Nepal that only a few members of her community could speak their mother tongue fluently. Fearing that the language would die out, her husband, Raja Mama Kusunda, taught her to speak it, but, because she has no one to converse with, she has started forgetting it.

"I know a bit of the Kusunda language but I have no one to talk to. My daughter cannot speak it and my husband passed away over five years ago," she said.

Raja Mama was the last person in her family to speak Kusunda natively. But he passed away on April 18, 2018.

Basundhara Gharti, former chairperson of the Nepal Federation of Indigenous Nationalities' (NFIN) Tanahun District Council, informed that Raja Mama married outside his ethnicity because he could not find a Kusunda woman. This made it difficult to pass on his language to his only daughter Simanta.

"This should worry us all," Gharti said, alarmed. "The Kusundas have their own language, culture and customs and the state should work to preserve them."

She called on concerned state bodies to implement a policy of studying and teaching mother tongues and culture. "Only this can protect Kusunda and other languages."

Kusundas are one of the last remaining hunter-gatherer communities of Nepal. Because of this, they are known as the king of the jungle. But, as per the NFIN's District Council, many Kusundas have integrated into the society due to deforestation, modernisation and other factors, and have married non-Kusundas. This has impacted their traditional lifestyle and language negatively.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

In the End, we will remember not the words of our enemies, but the silence of our friends.
- Martin Luther King, Jr.

EDITORIAL

Electricity Arrears Row

The issue related to electrify tariff and settlement of its arrears has become pertinent. Giving top priority to the issue, the government the other day decided to form a probe committee to resolve the electricity tariff dispute of dedicated feeders and trunk lines. According to Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears. Meanwhile the NEA had cut off the electricity supply to some industries having electricity arrears of more than Rs. 50 million. In the meantime, the NEA is directed to reconnect the lines of the defaulting industries. The issue is resolved temporarily but also demand a durable solution.

Once there was a time when all Nepali households and most of business enterprises were facing a crippling power outage of up to 18 hours a day. At the same time, some industries had been able to manage special facility of uninterrupted power supply from NEA through its dedicated feeders and trunk lines. The special facility of uninterrupted power supply to such industries was provided at the cost of increased load-shedding to the general people and other enterprises.

According to the NEA officials the dedicated and trunk lines facilities to the certain industries was provided with the condition of charging higher electricity tariffs. But when the NEA issued the electricity bill for dedicated feeder and trunk lines, most of such industries refused paying the bill saying that the bill amount was arbitrary and lacked facts. As industries refused to pay the additional tariffs, the disputes went to the level of cutting off electricity line of those industries by the NEA. This resulted in the halt of production of such industries and employment of workers involved.

After the request from the private sector organisations, the government has now taken the initiatives to settle the row on electricity bill of dedicated and trunk lines. A meeting of the Council of Ministers held at the Office of Prime Minister and Council of Ministers in Singha Durbar on Tuesday decided to form the committee headed by former Supreme Court judge Girish Chandra Lal. Jiblal Bhusal, Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, and a Joint Secretary from the Ministry of Energy will be the members of the committee. At the same time, the government has directed the NEA to reconnect the lines of different industries.

The NEA started to cut off the electricity supply of industries having electricity arrears since December 22, 2023. The Authority has disconnected the lines of 24 industries with arrears of more than Rs. 50 million. Out of this, Himal Steels has paid the outstanding amount in installments and after paying the first installment, the Authority has reconnected the line. According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears. Industrialists and workers have also been protesting against the power line cut off.

The private sector organisations including the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) and Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) are demanding impartial opinion on the disputes of electricity arrears between NEA and industries after analysing the past studies, current situation and Time of the Day (TOD) metres, among others. The government probe committee should examine the dispute impartially and give the reasonable solution to both NEA and industries. The probe committee should also be careful that its recommendation would not encourage the industries to make similar refusal of paying electricity tariff and arrears in the coming days.

Conclude Transitional Justice

MANJIMA DHAKAL

On the recent World Human Rights Day, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'invited conflict victims leaders from the decade-long conflict to his residence in Baluwatar. During the meeting, he reiterated his commitment to concluding the remaining work of the peace process. In that meeting, he sought the support of conflict victims for the ongoing process. True to his commitment, the Prime Minister has been consistently engaging in frequent meetings with the heads of major political parties to garner consensus on the Truth and Reconciliation (TRC). Besides, even in some public programmes, Prime Minister and his cabinet ministers are publicly committing to conclude the work soon.

However, a recent event tell a different story. A family of a disappeared person performed the last rituals for their loved one after being exhausted from 21 years of waiting. The reason is the delay in justice and finding the truth of the disappeared person. The family of disappeared Bhupendra Upreti of Nepalgunj performed his last rituals at Pasupati Aaryaghat. According to a news report, disappeared Upreti's wife, Chandrakala Upreti, who was in the last rituals, said that despite the cremation, she still has hope for her husband's return. Chandrakala said they were compelled to do the rituals after they received no support from the state.

The Upreti story is only emblematic. Numerous families neglected by even different governments and parties are losing hope in their pursuit of truth regarding their missing loved ones. Although the comprehensive peace agreement signed in 2005 states that the status of forcibly disappeared persons will be made public within 60 days, it has not yet been implemented. The government-formed disappeared commission received as many as 3,223 complaints of disappearance. Now the commission is without officials and the government is in process to bring new bill regarding the truth commission and commission related to disappeared persons.

As political parties and government don't seem serious about the pain of conflict victims, the international community should also take note of Nepal's struggles with transitional justice and apply pressure on the government to uphold human rights. Enforced disappearances are a gross violation, and the lack of resolution perpetuates a culture of impunity. The hope expressed by the Upreti family highlights the enduring faith in justice and the yearning for their loved one's return.

The recent movements of victims from both sides – state and opposition – appear that both victims and parties directly involved in the conflict are eager to conclude the transitional justice process. Families, spanning almost a generation, are fervently praying for the resolution of the TRC process due to the numerous difficulties they face in their daily lives. However, certain activist groups and some interest groups are indirectly attempting to derail the process.

Hence, as the new TRC bill is in the process of being tabled in the Parliament, all parliamentarians, political parties, human rights activists, and other stakeholders must earnestly work towards concluding the process, ensuring justice for victims. If Nepal successfully concludes the remaining peace process in a good manner, it will get recognition in the international community. Nepal could become a role model for the peaceful resolution of conflicts.

Nepal stands at a critical juncture where the government must translate promises into action, delivering on the commitments made in the peace agreement. The plight of families like the Upretis serves as a stark reminder that justice delayed is justice denied. Therefore, urgent steps are needed to address the long-standing grievances of the victims of enforced disappearance as well as other types of victims.

Mountain Agenda At COP28

Ways Forward For Nepal



Dr. Popular Gentle

At the heart of the 28th Conference of the Parties (COP28) to UNFCCC, the mountain agenda secured a pivotal role, shifting from the sidelines to become a core focus of climate change discussions. This reposition is crucial for countries like Nepal, where the Prime Minister's strong advocacy highlighted the profound impact of climate change on delicate mountain ecosystems and livelihoods of communities. Nepal's unique challenges, underscored by Nepal's leadership insights, bring a critical perspective to the fore, emphasising the urgency of integrating mountain resilience into the global climate action network. As the international community contemplates the way forward, Nepal's efforts and progress made thus far in championing mountain issues at the COP28 will be instrumental in shaping sustainable strategies to counter the environmental crisis faced by the least developed and mountainous countries.

In the lead-up to COP28, mountain agenda garnered significant momentum during the pre-COP consultations, underpinned by Nepal's comprehensive position paper which called for the international community to acknowledge and address the unique challenges faced by mountainous countries. The paper highlighted the vital ecological and cultural services provided by the Himalayas, and the dire impacts of climate change on these fragile ecosystems and the livelihoods they support.

This groundwork was further reinforced by the visit of UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres to Nepal between 29 October to 1 November, 2023, where he witnessed firsthand the devastating effects of climate change in the Everest and Annapurna regions. His subsequent address to Nepal's federal parliament resonated with urgency, employing the poignant phrase 'stop war against the nature' and advocating for committed international financial support for climate action.

Consultations

CAs part of its roadmap to COP28, Nepal's Ministry of Forests and Environment orchestrated comprehensive series of consultations, culminating in the first ever National Climate Summit in Nepal- a testament to the country's proactive and strategic approach. This meticulous planning facilitated Nepal's exemplary participation in COP28, marked by Prime Minister's impactful address and the debut of Nepal's Pavilion, setting a precedent for the nation's climate diplomacy.

At COP28, the global spotlight was turned towards the climate emergency facing mountainous regions, with a powerful opening remark from the UN Secretary General, who drew a striking parallel between his visits to the melting expanses of Antarctica and the retreating glaciers of Nepal. This set the stage for a series of high-level discussions emphasising the urgent need for climate action in these fragile environments. The Prime Minister of Nepal clutched the moment to elevate the mountain agenda, showcasing Nepal's leadership in advocating for ecosystems that are as interconnected globally as they are vulnerable.

The Prime Minister was a prominent figure at the COP28, participating in the high-level key sessions and events including the High-Level Leaders Event on Adaptation, High Level Roundtable on "Call of the Mountains and a side event on "Early Warning for All" on behalf of the group of the Least Developed Countries as well as his national capacity. Notably, his leadership during the "Call of the Mountains: Who Saves us from the Climate Crisis" roundtable exemplified Nepal's central role in driving the discourse on mountain climate crisis and ways forward. This session, which observed the gracious engagement of international dignitaries, including Prime Minister of Andorra, Foreign Minister of Kyrgyz Republic, UN Secretary General as well as representatives of Bhutan, international development and science based partners, underscored Nepal's capacity and commitment to steering the global mountain agenda. The Prime Minister's interactions with international leaders, including Prime Minister of India, President of Cuba, President of G77 and China, further reinforced Nepal's diplomatic endeavors in climate change advocacy.

In summary, the Prime Minister's strategic focus during COP28 was clear: to advocate for developed countries to urgently fulfil their financial commitments, to demand scaling up of climate finance to make up for the US $100 billion shortfall and double the adaptation finance by 2025 and to insist on fair and unconditional financial arrangements. His emphasis on climate finace as climate justice, a predictable loss and damage funds, and a clear roadmap from the Global Stocktake report underscored a strong stance on justice for Least Developed Countries (LDCs) and mountainous regions. Beyond high-level dialogues, Nepal's engagement was multifaceted, with its delegation participating in numerous side events and the Nepal Pavilion hosting around 40 critical discussions, illustrating the nation's holistic and proactive approach to tackling the climate crisis.

COP28 concluded with a bittersweet mix of achievements and ongoing challenges, reflecting the intricate dance of global climate negotiations. A significant victory of Nepal was the formal acknowledgement of the mountain agenda, setting a precedent for future discourses. The Global Stocktake (GST) outcomes from COP28 underpinned the criticality of mountain ecosystems, leading to an agreement to initiate an expert dialogue on the intersection of mountains and climate change at the upcoming sessions of the UNFCCC Subsidiary Body for Implementation (SBI) and Subsidiary Body for Scientific and Technological Advice (SBSTA). This acknowledgement serves as a testament of Nepal's persistent advocacy and represents a leap forward in ensuring that the unique needs of mountain regions are addressed within the broader climate action framework.

This pivotal conference also witnessed the introduction of the 'presidency youth climate champion' initiative, a nod to the vital role of youth in the climate movement, and the establishment of gender-responsive adaptation goals. These strides signify a growing recognition of inclusivity in climate action, embracing a more diverse range of voices and perspectives. Additionally, COP28 succeeded in setting thematic and dimensional targets under the global goal of adaptation, with a commitment to develop clear indicators and support the formulation and implementation of national adaptation plans.

The crowning achievement of COP28, however, was the operationalisation of loss and damage fund, a critical step towards financial justice for countries bearing the brunt of climate impacts. With some nations stepping forward with pledges, this fund represents a beacon of hope for vulnerable countries, ensuring that they have the necessary resources to recover from and adapt to the detrimental effects of a warming planet. This development marks a monumental step in the fight against climate change, offering tangible support to those who need it most.

As Nepal forges ahead following COP28, the most important ways forward hinges on solidifying its mountain agenda in global climate policy. The impending UNFCCC June conference presents a prime opportunity for Nepal to clarify and bolster the mountain agenda through focused dialogue. With Nepal's impending transition from an LDC to a developing country status in 2026, it is imperative to foster new alliances, as current affiliations like G77 and China may not fully align with it priorities. Establishing a dedicated mountain forum could offer a platform better tailored to representing Nepal's climate interests on the global stage.

Adaptation strategies

The operational details of the newly established Loss and Damage Fund may not be a simple and linear process for Nepal. Building its capacity to navigate, access and effectively utilise this mechanism is crucial. This effort extends to understanding the nuances of a just energy transition and revising adaptation targets in line with global goals. Moreover, a nuanced and skilled negotiation team, well-versed in Nepal's sectoral priorities, is essential to influence future climate dialogues effectively. For adaptation strategies, a focus on locally led principles is key, demanding enhanced decentralisation, tackling structural inequalities, and boosting local capacities. Despite Nepal's policy to allocate significant adaptation resources at the local level, institutional mechanisms and capacities currently fall short. The path to effective local adaptation relies on governmental reform and a genuine commitment to devolution.

Building on its proactive role in COP28, Nepal's future impact will be measured by its ability to refine its negotiation strategies and to secure and manage climate finance, enhanced capacity in effectively utilising resources and driving sustainable and resilient development for its people and the delicate mountain ecosystem they depend on.

(The author is the environmental and development expert to Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal "Prachanda".)

Challenge To Define Vision Of Socialism



Mukti Rijal

Socialism has become a catch word in the political realm of Nepal. Almost all political parties and leaders talk of socialism and swear by it in their manifestoes, statutes, documents and speeches. The federal Constitution of Nepal promises to build a socialist oriented state through implementation of appropriate social and economic measures. Socialism in Nepal has, therefore, become like a hat, as political thinker CEM Joad mentions, that has lost its shape because every leader and political parties claim that they wear it better than others do. Nepali Congress has indeed been the premier political organisation that has sworn by democratic socialism since its conceptualisation and establishment over eight decades ago. NC's founder leader, BP Koirala, was known as a socialist leader across South Asia, if not throughout the world. Moreover, his camaraderie with Indian socialist leaders like Dr. Ram Manohar Lohia, Jaya Prakash Narayan, Acharya Narendra Dev and many leaders of stature was meaningful and significant.

Equity

BP also held a place of mutual admiration and respect with these Indian leaders. He had joined and cooperated with these leaders in their struggle for India's freedom. In later part of life, BP was counted as a respected democratic socialist on par with German social democrat Willy Brandt and Swedish leader Olaf Palme, among others. BP's socialist thinking in later part of life, according to his writings, was influenced by German born British economist E.F Schumacher's who shot into global prominence due to his bestseller book "Small Is Beautiful: A Study of Economics As If People Mattered" published in 1973. The title of his book "Small Is Beautiful" came from a principle that advancing small, appropriate technologies, policies and polities offers a superior alternative to the mainstream ethos of "bigger is better".

BP broadly defined his approach to socialism in terms of appropriate and just redistribution of resources to ensure that even the poorest of the poor could lead equity based dignified living. However, his vision of socialism had not been articulated in concrete institutional and methodological terms. NC has seldom clarified its way of thinking on socialism though it has been imbibed into one of its ideological key pillars. However, NC pushed for neo-liberalist economic agenda by giving way to privatisation of health and education sector, among others, which should be taken care of by the state itself.

For several years during the cold war, Nepal's political landscape was largely dominated by communist parties of radical and moderate variations. The communist parties have won the democratic elections time and again and become an inalienable part of the ruling establishment for the last several years, playing an important role in democratisation movement. They have also worked closely with NC in the struggle to restore multiparty polity. Moreover, they organised powerful resistance to topple monarchy in Nepal. However, the radical

> Though the communist parties keep carrying Marxist-Leninist and Maoist tags, they seem to be preposterously bourgeoisie in their behaviours, taste, manner and conduct.

Maoist party that had launched armed insurrection for almost a decade has finally reconciled to peaceful and non-violent politics. Though the communist parties keep carrying Marxist-Leninist and Maoist tags, they seem to be preposterously bourgeoisie in their behaviours, taste, manner and conduct. Marx and Engels are quoted by British historian Eric Hobsbawm in his book "The Age of Capital" to have said that the bourgeoisie culture is so luring and powerful that it draws even the most primitive ones into its definition of the civilised class.

This is what has exactly happened in the case of the Nepali communists too. They have been irresistibly drawn into the world of bourgeoisie tastes, style, conduct and manner. Communist leaders have been part of liberalising and privatising education, health sectors and benefitted enormously from businesses in these sectors allegedly as rent seekers and enterpreneurs. Though, of late, some of the communist parties seem taking cognizance of the futility and ludicrousness of clinging to the communist tags and ideas for the fact that these have lost their meaning and relevance in today's world. They have come to network together under the banner of socialist alliance, even though they are still undecided to shed communist veneer fearing that this might tend to lose the traditional communist vote bank.

Evolving context

This dilemma stalks more to the CPN (UML) than any other communist parties as it resists to shed Marxist-Leninist trappings fearing that this would lead to weakening of its vote bastion in the electoral competition. CPN (UML) has not been part of the Socialist Alliance that was declared six months ago even though this party has long practiced political pluralism and multiparty politics in pragmatic consideration. It is reported that once ultra-radical party CPN (Maoist) is part of the so called Socialist Alliance and it is said to be mulling to shun its Maoist tag but not to wear off the communist cover. Former Prime Minister Madhav Nepal who split with KP Oli-led CPN (UML) almost two years ago named his newly created political formation as CPN (socialist).

Furthermore, former Prime Minister Dr. Babu Ram Bhattarai who was once a radical communist ideologue is ranted for his decisiveness to dissociate from his party CPN (Maoist) almost seven years ago and declare that the party is likely to lose ground if it fails to democratise and reform from within. He argues that communist parties should not shy away to reframe and rebrand democratically to retain their relevance in the evolving context. However, Dr. Bhattarai himself lacks clarity on the pathways in building socialist democratic state to respond to the needs of the time.

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50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 11, 1974

Improved Wheat Being Sown

Chautara, Jan.10: Improved varieties of wheat are being cultivated in 1360 hectares of land in Sindhupalchowk district this year, reports RSS.

READER'S MAIL

Stay Safe From Cold

It is winter season in Nepal along with the rest of the Northern Hemisphere. The cold can be quite adverse especially during cold waves which is why it is necessary to take precautions when it comes to preserving human lives. Hypothermia is fatal and since the Terai region of Nepal tends to witness cold waves, it is vital that services are provided to Terai citizens to tackle cold.

Lately, there has been a surge in cold and flu patients throughout Nepal. There are also fears of newly detected variant of coronavirus.

Thus, the government should ensure that citizens are not just safe but also aware when it comes to overcoming winter related health issues. Likewise, the air pollution seems to be



a severe problem in the winter season. Particularly, the Kathmandu Valley sees a rise in air pollution – to the chagrin of its residents. The government and private health sectors should collaborate so that people can get timely treatment from winter colds and flus.

Sita Chaudhary Banke

TAILPIECE

I don't have an attitude problem. You have a perception problem.

If swimming is so good for your figure, how do you explain whales?

I loathe people who keep dogs. They are cowards who haven't got the guts to bite people themselves.

On the keyboard of life, always keep one finger on the escape key.

I have not yet begun to procrastinate.

I don't suffer from stress. I'm just a carrier.

Tell me what you need, and I'll tell you how to get along without it.

Someday we'll look back on all this and plow into a parked car.

Deadly storms batter US

AFP
Florida, Jan. 10

Severe weather battered the United States Tuesday, spinning off tornadoes and reportedly killing three people in the South as high winds and blizzards buffeted the North and hundreds of thousands lost power.

Heavy rain leading to flash flooding, wind gusts likely more than 55 miles (80 kilometres) per hour, and thunderstorms struck the Eastern Seaboard from the Mid-Atlantic to the Northeast, according to the National Weather Service.

"Do not underestimate this one," warned New Jersey Governor Phil Murphy in an interview with local media.

He described the storm as "unusual," citing up to four inches of rain in January and high winds pummelling the shoreline.

The inclement weather even resulted in Vice President Kamala Harris's plane, Air Force 2, being diverted from landing at its normal spot, Joint Base Andrews, and instead heading to Dulles International Airport in Virginia.

Meanwhile, tornadoes ripped through the Southeast, including the Florida panhandle, where drone images showed downed trees and damaged buildings with roofs torn off.

At least three storm-related deaths occurred across a large, multi-state section of the South.

One person was killed in a North Carolina mobile home park where multiple homes were damaged, according to Catawba County government officials.

Another died when a tree fell across the windshield of a vehicle in Jonesboro, Georgia just south of Atlanta, the Clayton County Police Department said.



PHOTO: AP

A resident checks a collapsed roof after a line of storms roared through the area of Perdido Key near Pensacola, Florida, U.S. January 9, 2024.

And an 81-year-old woman was killed in Alabama when a tornado struck her mobile home and sent it rolling multiple times, local media said, citing the Houston County coroner.

More than 890,000 customers had lost power in the United States as of Tuesday evening, mainly in the East, according to monitoring website Poweroutage.us.

In the central part of the country heavy snowfall (at a rate of 1-2 inches per hour) hit the upper Midwest and was shifting into the Great Lakes region, the weather service said.

And in the Northwest, the first blizzard warnings in a decade were issued for the Cascade and Olympic mountains, according to the New York Times.

The blizzard conditions were expected to continue into Wednesday "brining snow totals to several feet" in the region, according to the NWS.

The weather was already having a heavy impact on flights, with more than 1,300 cancelled and 8,600 delayed in the United States on Tuesday, monitoring website FlightAware.com reported.

Some of the cancellations were due to the grounding of some Boeing 737 MAX jets for inspection after a panel ripped off an Alaska Airlines plane mid-flight last week.

Scientists say that as humanity continues to warm the planet by burning fossil fuels, weather patterns will become more unpredictable.

That will mean wetter and more powerful storms, along with hotter, drier periods that will strain our water resources.

Ecuador orders military to 'neutralize' gangs

AFP
Guayaquil, Jan. 10

Ecuador's president gave orders on Tuesday to "neutralize" criminal gangs after gunmen stormed and opened fire in a TV studio, as bandits threatened random executions on a second day of terror in the country.

Gangs declared war on the government when President Daniel Noboa announced a state of emergency following the prison escape on Sunday of one of Ecuador's most powerful narco bosses.

Noboa ordered military operations to "neutralize" criminal gangs, as the country exploded into what he called an "internal armed conflict".

Long a peaceful haven sandwiched between top cocaine exporters Colombia and Peru, Ecuador has seen violence explode in recent years as rival gangs with links to Mexican and Colombian cartels vie for control. In the port city of Guayaquil, men wearing balaclavas and waving weapons stormed a state-owned TV station during a live broadcast, taking several journalists and staff members hostage on Tuesday.

At least 10 people have been killed in a series of attacks blamed on gangs – eight in Guayaquil, and two "viciously murdered by armed criminals" in the nearby town of Nobol, police said Tuesday.

Three other officers were wounded in Guayaquil.After the escape of Jose Adolfo Macias, aka "Fito" – leader of Ecuador's biggest gang Los Choneros – Noboa on Monday declared a nationwide state of emergency and nightly curfew.

On Tuesday they stormed a studio of state-owned TC Television in Guayaquil with guns and explosives. Hooded attackers fired gunshots during a live TC broadcast as a woman could be heard pleading: "Don't shoot, please don't shoot."

The intruders forced terrified crew onto the ground and a person could be heard screaming as the studio lights went out but the broadcast continued.

Police entered the studio after about 30 minutes of chaos.

Noboa, 36, who was elected last year on a pledge to fight drug-related violence, ordered the military operations against gangs he described as "terrorist organizations and belligerent non-state actors."

Authorities reported multiple explosions and cars set alight on Tuesday, including in the capital Quito, and said seven police officers had been kidnapped.

A video circulating on social media showed three of the kidnapped officers sitting on the ground with a gun pointed at them as one was forced to read a statement addressed to Noboa.

"You declared war, you will get war," the visibly terrified officer read.

"You declared a state of emergency. We declare police, civilians and soldiers to be the spoils of war." The statement added that anyone found on the street after 11:00 pm "will be executed."

There was panic on the streets, with shops and businesses in various cities closing early and residents rushing home as face-to-face classes were suspended nationwide until Friday.

The head of Ecuador's Joint Command of the Armed Forces, Jaime Vela, said that gangs had "committed bloody acts without precedent".

Houthis launch Red Sea missile attack

AP
Dubai, United Arab Emirates, Jan. 10

Yemen's Houthi rebels fired their largest-ever barrage of drones and missiles targeting shipping in the Red Sea, forcing the United States and British navies to shoot down the projectiles in a major naval engagement, authorities said Wednesday. No damage was immediately reported.

The attack by the Iranian-backed Houthis came despite a planned United Nations Security Council vote later Wednesday to potentially condemn and demand an immediate halt to the attacks by the rebels, who say their assaults are aimed at stopping Israel's war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

However, their targets increasingly have tenuous — or no — relationship with Israel and imperil a crucial trade route linking Asia and the Middle East to Europe.

That raises the risk of a U.S. retaliatory strike on Yemen that could upend an uneasy cease-fire that's held in the Arab world's poorest country.

The assault happened off the Yemeni port cities of Hodeida and Mokha, according to the private intelligence firm Ambrey. In the Hodeida attack, Ambrey said ships described over radio seeing missiles and drones, with U.S.-allied warships in the area urging "vessels to proceed at maximum speed."

Off Mokha, ships saw missiles fired, a drone in the air and small vessels trailing them, Ambrey said early Wednesday.

The British military's United Kingdom Marine Trade Operations also acknowledged the attack off Hodeida.

The U.S. military's Central Command said the "complex attack" launched by the Houthis included bomb-carrying drones, anti-ship cruise missiles and one anti-ship ballistic missile.

It said 18 drones, two cruise missiles and the anti-ship missile were downed by F-18s from the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower, as well as by American Arleigh Burke-class destroyers the USS Gravely, the USS Laboon and the USS Mason, as well as the United Kingdom's HMS Diamond.

"This is the 26th Houthi attack on commercial shipping lanes in the Red Sea since Nov. 19," Central Command said. "There were no injuries or damage reported."

"Vessels are advised to transit with caution and report any suspicious activity," the UKTMO added.

British Defense Secretary Grant Shapps described the assault as "the largest attack by the Iranian-backed Houthis in the Red Sea to date," saying the Diamond used Sea Viper missiles and guns to shoot down multiple drones.

The Houthis, a Shiite group that's held Yemen's capital since 2014, did not formally acknowledge launching the attacks. However, the pan-Arab satellite news network Al Jazeera quoted an anonymous Houthi military official saying their forces "targeted a ship linked to Israel in the Red Sea," without elaborating.

DR Congo court confirms Tshisekedi won election

AFP
DR Congo, Jan. 10

DR Congo's Constitutional Court on Tuesday confirmed President Felix Tshisekedi's landslide victory in a December election for a second term in the poor but mineral-rich massive central African country.

Tshisekedi got 73.47 per cent of vote during a December 20 election, the court said.

The Democratic Republic of Congo held a presidential, legislative, regional and local election on December 20 that opposition leaders had called a "sham".

Nine opposition candidates signed a declaration in late December rejecting what they termed a "sham" election and called for a re-run.

More than 40 million people out of the 100 million inhabitants of the vast country were registered to vote on December 20 for president, as well as for national and regional lawmakers and municipal councillors.

Voting was officially extended by a day to account for problems, and continued for days afterwards in remote areas, according to observers.

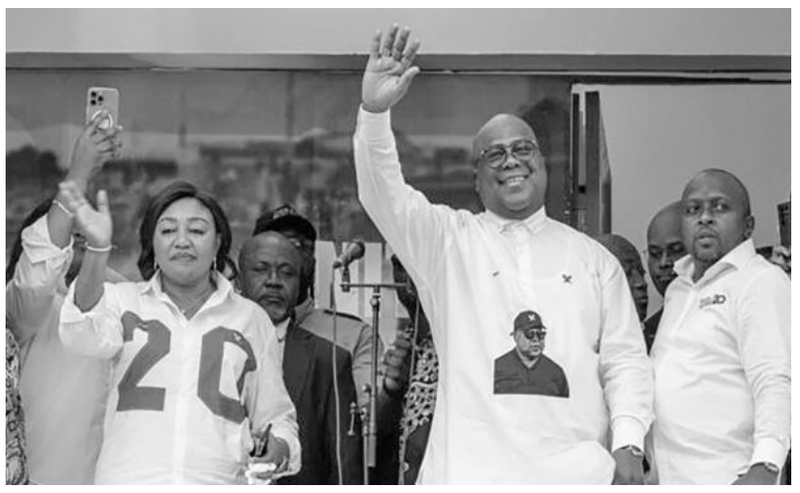


PHOTO: AP

The President Felix Tshisekedi (2nd R) got 73.47 per cent of vote during a December 20 election, the court said.

The final figures announced by the court on Tuesday differed only slightly from provisional results that election officials had already made public.

Following Tshisekedi is Moise Katumbi, a former governor of the central Katanga region with 18.08 per cent.

Martin Fayulu -- who says he was robbed of the last presidential election in 2018 -- got 4.92 percent.

Former prime minister Adolphe Muzito got 1.13 per cent and Denis Mukwege, who won a Nobel Peace Prize for his work with female victims of wartime sexual violence, got less than one percent.

In its ruling on Tuesday, the court also rejected an appeal by a candidate who came in last to annul the results.

Over 50 countries go to the polls in 2024

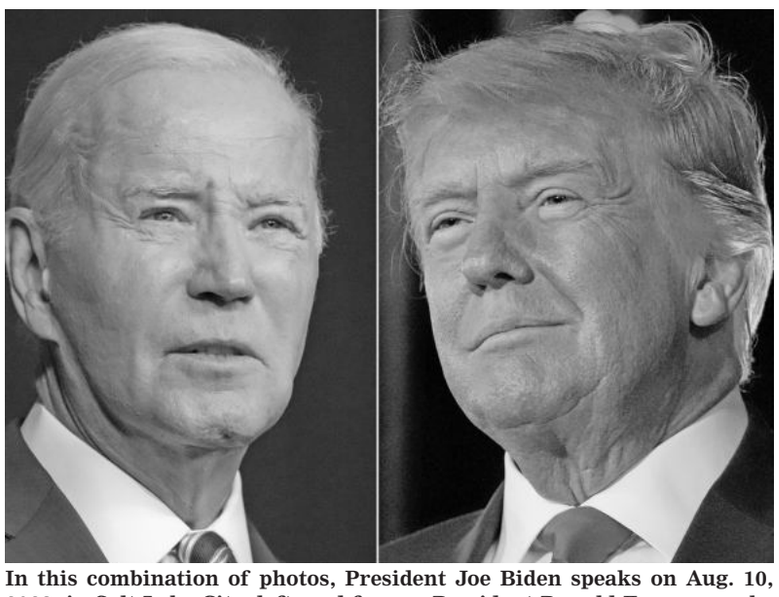
AP
London, Jan. 10

More than 50 countries that are home to half the planet's population are due to hold national elections in 2024, but the number of citizens exercising the right to vote is not unalloyed good news. The year looks set to test even the most robust democracies and to strengthen the hands of leaders with authoritarian leanings.

From Russia and the United Kingdom to India, El Salvador and South Africa, the presidential and legislative contests have huge implications for human rights, economies, international relations and prospects for peace in a volatile world.

In some countries, the balloting will be neither free nor fair. And in many, curbs on opposition candidates, weary electorates and the potential for manipulation and disinformation have made the fate of democracy a front-and-centre campaign issue.

A possible rematch between President Joe Biden and his predecessor Donald Trump looms large in the election calendar; a Trump victory in November



In this combination of photos, President Joe Biden speaks on Aug. 10, 2023, in Salt Lake City, left, and former President Donald Trump speaks on July 8, 2023, in Las Vegas.

is perhaps the greatest global wildcard. Yet high-stakes votes before then also will gauge the "mood of dissatisfaction, impatience, uneasiness" among far-flung electorates, said Bronwen Maddox, director of the London-based think-tank Chatham House.

Bangladeshi Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, the world's longest-serving female leader, won a fourth successive term Monday in an election that opposition parties boycotted and preceded by violence. Hasina's Awami League party was re-elected on a low turnout of 40%, and the stifling of dissent risks triggering political turmoil.

India, the world's most populous country, is due to hold a general election by mid-2024 that is likely to bring Prime Minister Narendra Modi of the right-wing Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party a third consecutive term.

To his supporters, Modi is a political outsider who has cleaned up after decades of corruption and made India an emerging global power. Critics say assaults on the press and free speech, as well as attacks on religious minorities by Hindu nationalists, have grown brazen on his watch.

Another leader seeking to retain power is El Salvador President Nayib Bukele, who has won widespread support since using emergency powers for an aggressive crackdown on ultra-violent street gangs.

A Supreme Court filled by his party's appointees cleared Bukele to run on Feb. 4 despite a constitutional ban on presidents serving two consecutive terms. While foreign governments have criticized the suspension of some civil rights, Bukele is not expected to face serious competition.

Mexico is poised to elect its first female president on June 2 -- either former Mexico City Mayor Claudia Sheinbaum, a protégé of President Andrés Manuel López Obrador, or a former opposition senator, Xóchitl Gálvez. The winner will govern a country with daunting drug-related violence and an increasingly influential military.

Voters in Indonesia, Southeast Asia's largest democracy, are choosing a successor to President Joko Widodo on Feb. 14. Opinion polls indicate a close race between Defense Minister Prabowo Subianto, a right-wing nationalist, and former Central Java Gov. Ganjar Pranowo, the governing party's candidate.

Subianto's running mate is outgoing leader Widodo's son, prompting speculation of a dynasty in the making. Either winner, though, would mark a continuation of the corruption-tainted politics that have dominated Indonesia since the end of the Suharto dictatorship in 1998.

PRISM

Man punches punching bag for 55 hours

New Delhi: A 42-year-old martial artist in India broke a Guinness World Record when he spent 55 hours, 15 minutes throwing punches at a punching bag.

Sidhu Kshetri was required by Guinness World Records rules to throw at least one punch every 2 seconds and was allowed a 5-minute break each hour, which he was allowed to bank for longer breaks.

"I have been practicing martial arts for the last 25 years," Kshetri told Guinness World Records. "I am interested in contributing to my country, so I decided to attempt this world record."

Kshetri broke the previous record by 5 minutes.

Cat missing for 7 years found at factory

Northamptonshir: A British woman was reunited with her lost cat after 7 years when the feline was found to be living at a factory just 300 yards from home.

Stephanie Barstow of Corby, Northamptonshire, said her Bengal cat, Duke, failed to return home after a fight with his feline sibling, Nero, in January 2017, and she eventually gave up after months of searching.

Barstow said she was shocked when a knock at her door turned out to be a veterinarian telling her Duke had been found.

"She asked me if I was the owner of a cat called Duke -- I couldn't believe it," Barstow told Wales Online. "She told me that he had been found just 300 yards away from my home at a factory. I was absolutely shocked -- I just completely broke down."

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

532 – Nika riots in Constantinople: A quarrel between supporters of different chariot teams—the Blues and the Greens—in the Hippodrome escalates into violence.
1055 – Theodora is crowned empress of the Byzantine Empire.
1158 – Vladislaus II, Duke of Bohemia becomes King of Bohemia.
1569 – First recorded lottery in England.[6]
1787 – William Herschel discovers Titania and Oberon, two moons of Uranus.
1805 – The Michigan Territory is created.
1861 – American Civil War: Alabama secedes from the United States.
1863 – American Civil War: The three-day Battle of Arkansas Post concludes as General John McClernand and Admiral David Dixon Porter capture Fort Hindman and secure control over the Arkansas River for the Union.
1863 – American Civil War: CSS Alabama encounters and sinks the USS Hatteras off Galveston Lighthouse in Texas.

SUBEDI NEW SECRETARY AT MOCIT



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Ram Krishna Subedi has assumed office as the new secretary at the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MoCIT).

Subedi was transferred to the ministry from the National Natural Resources and Fiscal Commission (NNRFC) while his predecessor Krishna Bahadur Raut has been transferred to the Commission from the ministry.

Subedi has previously served as the Chief District Officer of several districts and has been the spokesperson for the Ministry of Home Affairs. He has also handled secretarial responsibilities at the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology and the Office of the Vice President.

Before coming to the NNRFC, has was the Chief Secretary of Madhes Province.

Welcoming the new secretary, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that the communication sector had evolved a lot, but the laws had not kept pace. "Our ministry is tasked with overseeing and representing the modern era but the laws we have to do that are very old and in need of amendment."

Secretary Subedi insisted that MoCIT had a special role as it was directly connected with the people. He also said that the ministry needed to work sensitively as it had the responsibility of introducing Nepal to the world.

RULING COALITION FORMS COORDINATION BODY FOR NA POLL

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The first meeting of the National Assembly Election Central Coordination Committee-2080, a joint committee of the ruling coalition, held on Wednesday decided to form provincial coordination committees and district coordination committees.

The meeting decided to form National Assembly Election Provincial Coordination Committee-2080 in all seven provinces and National Assembly Election District Coordination Committee-2080 in all 77 districts to elect the candidates of the ruling coalition.



PHOTO: RSS

A health worker administering vaccine against rubella virus, chickenpox and typhoid in Birendranagar of Surkhet district on Wednesday.

Blinken seeks Palestinian governance reform for postwar Gaza

AP
Tel Aviv, Israel, Jan. 10

Secretary of State Antony Blinken spoke to President Mahmoud Abbas on Wednesday about reforming the Palestinian self-rule government, as part of U.S. efforts to rally the region behind postwar plans for Gaza that also include concrete steps toward a Palestinian state.

Blinken says he has secured commitments from multiple countries in the region to assist with rebuilding and governing Gaza after Israel's war against Hamas, and that wider Israeli-Arab normalization is still possible, but only if there is "a pathway to a Palestinian state."

In their meeting Wednesday in the West Bank city of Ramallah, Blinken told Abbas that the U.S. supports "tangible steps towards the creation of a Palestinian state," according to State Department spokesman Matthew Miller. He said the two discussed administrative reform.

The vision outlined by Blinken faces serious obstacles. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government is adamantly opposed to the creation of a Palestinian state alongside Israel, and the autocratic, Western-backed Palestinian leadership, whose forces were driven from Gaza when Hamas took over in 2007, lacks legitimacy in the view of many Palestinians.

The war in Gaza is still raging with no end in sight, fueling a humanitarian catastrophe in the tiny coastal enclave. The fighting has also stoked escalating violence between Israel and Lebanon's Hezbollah militants that has raised fears of a wider conflict.

On his fourth visit to the region since the war began three months ago, Blinken has met in recent days with the leaders of Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates and Turkey. He says they are open to contributing to postwar plans in return for progress on creating a Palestinian state.

The Saudi Ambassador to the U.K. went even further on Tuesday, telling the BBC that the kingdom is still interested in a landmark normalization agreement with Israel, but that it must include "nothing less than an independent state of Palestine."

"One doesn't come without the other," Prince Khalid bin Bandar said.

After meeting with Netanyahu and other top Israeli officials on Tuesday, Blinken delivered a stark message, saying Israel must stop undercutting the Palestinians' ability to govern themselves with its expansion of settlements, home demolitions and evictions in the West Bank.

But he also said the Palestinian Authority "has a responsibility to reform itself, to improve its governance," and that he would discuss that with the 88-year-old Abbas, who has not stood for elections since 2005 and lacks support among his own people.

The Palestinian Authority governs parts of the Israeli-occupied West Bank under interim peace deals reached in the 1990s and cooperates with Israel on security matters. But it has been powerless to prevent the expansion of settlements in occupied territory it wants for a future state, and there have been no serious or substantive peace talks since Netanyahu returned to office in 2009.

U.S. President Joe Biden's administration has been unable to get Israel to make even relatively minor concessions to the Palestinians, like turning over all the tax revenue it collects on their behalf, or allowing the reopening of a U.S. Consulate to serve Palestinians in Israeli-annexed east Jerusalem.

Later Wednesday, Abbas was set to met with the leaders of Jordan and Egypt, two U.S. allies who have long served as mediators in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, in Jordan's Red Sea city of Aqaba.

Israel has vowed to keep fighting until it crushes Hamas and returns scores of hostages held by the group after its Oct. 7 attack that triggered the war. Israeli officials say the campaign will continue through the rest of the year, and its own postwar plans call for open-ended military control over the territory, from which it withdrew soldiers and settlers in 2005.

Nearly 85% of Gaza's population of 2.3 million have been driven from their homes by the fighting, and a quarter of its residents face starvation, with only a trickle of food, water, medicine and other supplies entering through an Israeli siege.

Blinken said more food, water, medicine and other aid needs to enter and be distributed effectively, and he called on Israel to "do everything it can to remove any obstacles."

The offensive has reduced much of northern Gaza, including Gaza City, to a moonscape, raising concerns over whether the hundreds of thousands of Palestinians who fled from those areas will ever be able to return. Far-right members of Netanyahu's government have called for them to be resettled elsewhere, which critics say would amount to ethnic cleansing.

WB makes 5% growth projection for Nepal

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The World Bank has projected that Nepal's economic growth will be 5 per cent in the next fiscal year 2024/25.

According to the World Bank's latest Global Economic Prospects report, it is estimated that Nepal will achieve 5 per cent economic growth in the next fiscal year 2024/25.

The growth is projected to pick up in Nepal, with monetary policy easing and the delayed effects of lifting import restrictions, said the report.

The WB has already estimated that Nepal will achieve 3.9 per cent economic growth in the current fiscal year 2023/24. Last year, the economic growth rate of Nepal was limited to 1.9 per cent.

The growth in South Asian Region is expected to edge slightly lower to a still-robust 5.6 per cent pace in 2024, before firming to 5.9 per cent next year.

The domestic demand, including public consumption and investment, will remain major driver of economic growth. A pickup in external demand, albeit still subdued, is also expected to contribute to growth, said the WB.

In India, growth is expected to edge up to 6.4 per cent in FY2024/25 (April 2024 to March 2025) after softening to 6.3 per cent in FY2023/24. The WB has projected that the economic growth of India will be at 6.5 per cent in the fiscal year 2025/26.

In Bangladesh, growth is forecast to slow to 5.6 per cent in FY2023/24. The outlook in Pakistan remains subdued for FY2023/24. Monetary policy is expected to remain tight to contain inflation, while fiscal policy is also set to be contractionary, said the WB.

The outlook in Sri Lanka remains uncertain, amid debt restructuring negotiations, particularly with private creditors.

Investment related to the tourism sector will support growth in Maldives, while the commissioning of a new hydro plant in Bhutan is expected to contribute to a pickup in growth in the next fiscal year.

Former DIG Shah sentenced to three years in prison

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The Special Court has sentenced former Nepal Police Deputy Inspector General (DIG) Mahesh Bikram Shah to three years in prison.

The bench of special court chairperson Teknarayan Kunwar and members Tejnarayan Singh Rai and Ritendra Thapa handed down the verdict today, after finding ex-DIG and popular litterateur Shah guilty of corruption.

The court convicted two people including the then DIG Shah in the case of misappropriation of funds when he was the head of the Regional Police Training Office.

The Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority had filed a case of corruption against Shah claiming a refund of Rs. 1.6 million. The court ruled that the same amount should be recovered along with three years imprisonment.

Similarly, in the same case, the court sentenced former Nepal Police sub-inspector Dipendra Prasad Paneru to three years in prison along with a fine of Rs. 1.6 million.

Parties should build capacity: UML General-Secretary

RSS
Gulmi, Jan. 10

CPN (UML) General-Secretary Shankar Pokhrel asserted that democracy would be stronger if the political parties chosen by the public could be established in the democratic manner.

At a training organized by his party's district committee in Gulmi district today, General-Secretary Pokhrel voiced his concerns that political instability and social chaos were on the rise in the country lately.

Pokhrel further expressed his concern over people's growing distrust over democracy and thus called for the political parties to build up capacity to iron out the weaknesses of democracy.

The former Minister argued that there was no alternative for the country to move ahead in the path of development and prosperity so as to prevent anarchist elements that were on the prowl in the political sector of the country.

He viewed that all forces blamed that everyone had started attacking and targeting his party, the major opposition party in the federal parliament.

On the occasion, General-Secretary Pokhrel instructed the party cadres and leaders to present themselves as leaders not only in the political and theoretical affairs but also in the economic and developmental ones.

According to him, his party had launched the 'Mission Grassroot' to sensitize the public about the good deeds it did when it led the government over various period of time as well as to strengthen the party ideologically and organizationally.

The three-day training is attended by party's prominent central leaders and cadres from the district, informed Balsing Kaucha, the party's district Chairperson.

Minister Sharma opens Telecom's....

Rukum West are districts of remote areas, she held the view that achievements can be made through mutual coordination initiatives of people's representatives and officials and employees at the same level by determining development priorities.

Purna Bahadur Gharti, a member of the House of Representatives from Rukum, expressed his gratitude for delivering high-speed internet to the headquarters and requested that the service be extended to the villages.In the event presided over by Krishna Bahadur Raut, Secretary of the Ministry and Chairman of Nepal Telecom Board of Directors, Acting Managing Director of Telecom, Sangeeta Pahari informed about the service delivery of the company.

With the inauguration of FTTH service in two districts, the FTTH service has been expanded to 74 districts.

The optical fiber is yet to reach Humla, Mugu and Dolpa in Karnali Province. Informing that Nepal Telecom has planned to extend the access of FTTH service to two more districts Mugu and Dolpa in its annual programme, Minister Sharma requested to proceed with this work as soon as possible.

PM to visit Uganda to attend....

to appoint the chairperson and expert members to determine compensation for private land and other structures within the right of way of the Godak Soyat 132 KV transmission line project in ward numbers 9, 10 and 11 Ilam Municipality to maintain 18 metres right of way, nine metres each on right and left side of the project.

Similarly, the government has extended the work procedure-2023 prepared as per the Section 42 of the Enforced Disappearances, Enquiry, Truth and Reconciliation Commission Act, 2014, till July 15, 2024, and decided to issue the Order to Remove Difficulty in the Nepal Gazette and allowed the government to table the same order in the House of Representatives.

The government has also appointed Devendra Raj Dhakal of Nepal Judicial Service to the position of Chief Registrar of the Supreme Court following his promotion.

Likewise, the government transferred Secretary Krishna Bahadur Raut of the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology to the Office of the National Natural Resources and Fiscal Commission (NNFRC) as secretary and Secretary Ram Krishna Subedi of the Commission to the Ministry.

'India cannot execute projects....

will also have the District Coordination Officer and subject experts as members. Authorised representatives from MoFAGA, MoF, Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Indian embassy will review the project's progress every two months.

Prime Minister Prachanda also informed that the January 4 agreement was a continuation of previous agreements and explained that, while the exact methodology differed, other countries like Japan, China, the United Kingdom, Australia, as well as United Nations agencies, also implemented projects in similar ways.

"The present agreement does not contain any such provision that allows India to choose and execute projects unilaterally," he emphasised.

All agencies...

responsible for the Implementation of the National Security Policy-2019, shared their views on the progress in the matters assigned to their respective ministries and agencies, the problems and challenges faced in the implementation, and the steps and measures to be taken in the future for the effective implementation of the action plan.

In the review meeting, National Security Adviser Shanker Das Bairagi pointed out that since the National Security Policy is a policy to strengthen the nation and the people, other policies of the government should be formulated and implemented in harmony with this policy.

Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS) General Prabhu Ram Sharma of Nepali Army emphasised that the national security policy is not only a subject of the Ministry of Defence and the Nepali Army, but also a matter of common responsibility of all the ministries and agencies of the government.

The meeting was attended by the secretaries of various ministries, Nepali Army generals, Nepal Police, Armed Police Force Nepal and the head of the National Investigation Department, as well as focal persons related to security policy implementation of various ministries and agencies. The programme was concluded under the chairmanship of Baburam Adhikari, Acting Secretary of the Ministry of Defence.

Ukraine's Zelenskyy says Russia can be stopped but Kyiv badly needs more air defense systems

AP
Vilnius, Lithuania, Jan. 10

Ukraine has shown the world that Russia's military can be stopped, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Wednesday as he began a visit to the Baltic nations in search of more help for his country against the Kremlin's larger and better-supplied forces in the 22-month-old invasion.

Speaking in the Lithuanian capital of Vilnius, Zelenskyy said Ukraine still must bolster its air defenses against Russia's intensified missile and drone onslaughts and replenish its ammunition supplies as long-range strikes become the main feature of this winter's fighting.

"We have proven that Russia can be stopped, that deterrence is possible," he said after talks with Lithuanian President Gitanas Nauseda on his first foreign trip of the year.

The massive Russian barrages — more than 500 drones and missiles were fired between Dec. 29 and Jan. 2, according to officials in Kyiv — are using up Ukraine's weapons stockpiles, however. The escalation is stretching Ukraine's air defense resources and leaving the country vulnerable unless it can secure further weapons supplies.

"We lack modern air defense systems badly," Zelenskyy said, noting that they are "what we need the most."

He acknowledged, however, that stockpiles are low in countries that could provide such materiel. "Warehouses are empty. And there are many challenges to world defense," he said.



PHOTO: AP

In this photo provided by the Ukrainian President Press Office, Lithuania's President Gitanas Nauseda, left, and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy attend a welcoming ceremony in Presidential Courtyard, Vilnius, Lithuania, Jan. 10.

Ukraine hopes to accelerate development of its domestic defense industry and establish joint projects with foreign governments to speed up ammunition and weapons production.

Ukrainian officials traveling with Zelenskyy signed several documents on cooperation on joint arms production. Similar agreements are expected in the other Baltic countries Zelenskyy is expected to visit this week.

The focus of his two-day trip to Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia, Zelenskyy said on his official Telegram channel, will be security concerns, Ukraine's hopes to join the European Union and NATO, and building partnerships in drone production and electronic warfare capacities.

Zelenskyy thanked Lithuania for its military assistance and goodwill. He was expected in Estonia and Latvia on Thursday.

'Rap Battle Nepal' to be held from April



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The rap song reality show 'Rap Battle Nepal' is set to be held from April.

Organising a press conference in Kathmandu on Wednesday, the organisers Youzeesa International and Rajya Media Network officially announced the rap singing reality show.

The organisers informed that the show will be aired on AP1 Television from April.

Sanu Khan, Executive Director of Youzeesa International, said that the auditions for the show will begin in February.

He informed that the judging panel will include musicians from both the Nepali and Bollywood music industries.

Saroj Ojha, Chairman of Rajya Media Network, said that the show aims to create an environment for diverse audiences, including the youth, to enjoy the musical atmosphere.

The auditions will take place in various locations, including Kathmandu, Pokhara, Jhapa, Itahari, and Chitwan within Nepal, as well as in Darjeeling, Siliguri, and Sikkim in India.

Devil Singh Rajput, the event director, said that auditions are scheduled for February 8 in Darjeeling, February 10 in Sikkim, and February 12 in Siliguri in India.

Likewise, Nepal auditions will begin on February 14 in Jhapa, followed by February 17 in Itahari, February 21 in Chitwan, February 24 in Pokhara, and March 1 and 2 in Kathmandu.

Rajput also informed that digital auditions will be organised for Nepali speakers living around the world.

Anna joins 'Aktor' with Pradeep

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10



Actress Anna Sharma has recently joined the final cast of the upcoming film 'Aktor,' where she will star alongside lead actor Pradeep Khadka.

According to the film unit, a few days ago, the production team and Anna officially signed an agreement in this regard.

The collaboration between Pradeep and Anna in 'Aktor' marks their first on-screen pairing, and the chemistry between these two actors is expected to elevate the overall excitement surrounding the film.

Thaman Kumar Bhandari has invested in the production of 'Aktor,' which is under the direction of Rajan Bhusal.

Anish Bhusal serves as the co-producer for the project, brought to life by Adhreet Films.

Scheduled to commence shooting in a few months, the cinematography of the film will be directed by Narendra Mainali.

The production team aims to release 'Aktor'in 2025.

Actress Sharma shared her excitement about working in 'Aktor' and emphasised her eagerness to collaborate with a talented team.

Tom Cruise and Warner Bros Discovery teams up for films deal



REUTERS
Los Angeles, Jan. 10

Warner Bros Discovery (WBD.O) said on Tuesday it had struck a deal with Tom Cruise, one of Hollywood's most bankable actors, to develop and produce original and franchise theatrical films in 2024.

The film partnership with Cruise marks a coup for Warner Bros Motion Picture Group's co-chairs, Michael De Luca and Pam Abdy, and fulfills CEO David Zaslav's oft-stated desire to work with top talent behind the camera and in front of the camera.

"Inking a deal with arguably the biggest movie star in the world, Tom Cruise, is hugely significant," said Comscore senior media analyst Paul Dergarabedian. b"Talent attracts talent and every studio touts their formal arrangements with high-profile filmmakers and stars so as to signify to the world their commitment to these highly coveted creatives."

Cruise, who played a leading role in such films as "Top Gun," "The Last Samurai" and the "Mission: Impossible" series, and will occupy an office on the Warner Bros Discovery lot in Burbank, as have stars such as Clint Eastwood and Frank Sinatra.

Across his five-decade career, Cruise's movies have earned more than $12 billion globally, with the 2022 release of "Top Gun: Maverick," grossing nearly $1.5 billion, according to measurement firm Comscore. His most recent film, "Mission: Impossible -- Dead Reckoning Part One" brought in a more earthbound $568 million in worldwide box office proceeds.

The arrangement with Warner Bros is non-exclusive, with Cruise working on the next installment in the "Mission: Impossible" franchise for Paramount Pictures, according to one source.

Warner Bros and the other major studios are working to rebound from a protracted work stoppage, as Hollywood writers and later, its actors, walked off the job in 2023.

Writers and actors from Hollywood went on strike demanding higher wages and protection against the use of artificial intelligence (AI) in filmmaking.

The dual strikes shut down a large portion of film and television production, halted late-night talk shows and forced broadcast networks to fill TV slots with repeats of reality shows.

The strikes led to a delay in Cruise's next "Mission Impossible" film as production house Paramount Global (PARA.O) also bore the brunt of one of the longest work stoppages in the U.S. entertainment industry history.

ADAN CANTO DIES AT 42



AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 10

Adan Canto, the Mexican singer and actor best known for his roles in "X-Men: Days of Future Past" and "Agent Game" as well as the TV series "The Cleaning Lady," has died. He was 42. Publicist Jennifer Allen, told The Associated Press Canto died of appendiceal cancer and had opted to keep his diagnosis private.

"Adan had a depth of spirit that few truly knew. Those who glimpsed it were changed forever," Allen wrote in a statement. "He will be greatly missed by so many."

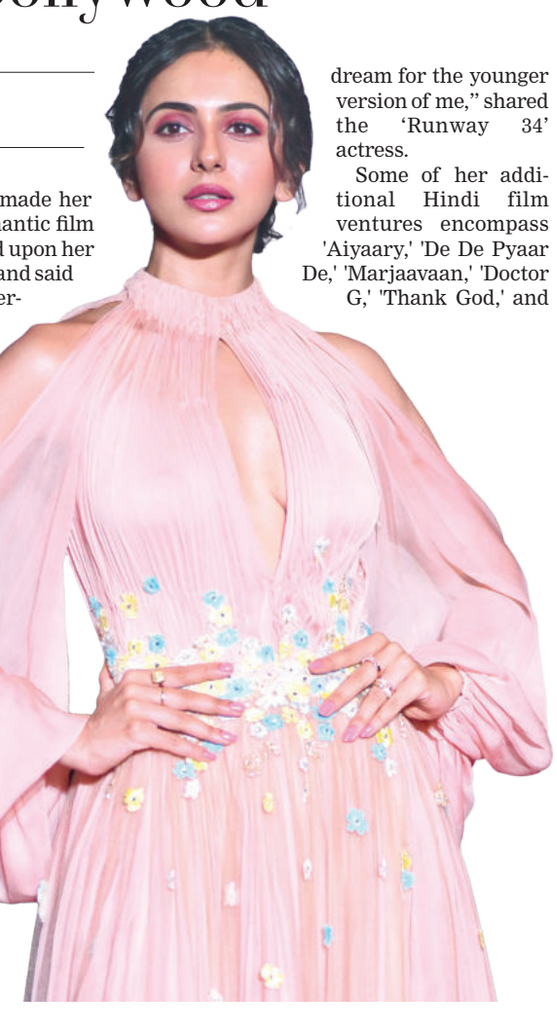
Born in Ciudad Acuña, Coahuila, Mexico and raised in Texas, Canto began his career at age 16, when he left home for Mexico City to work as a singer-songwriter. He then began pursuing acting, making his TV debut on the 2009 Mexican series "Estado de Gracia." His American debut came later, on Kevin Williamson's 2013 Fox drama series "The Following," which starred Kevin Bacon.

His notable roles include Vice President-elect Aaron Shore on "Designated Survivor," Colombian politician Rodrigo Lara Bonilla on "Narcos," and others.

Canto is survived by his wife, Stephanie Ann Canto, and two children, Roman Alder, 3, and Eve Josephine, 18 months.

Rakul Preet Singh celebrates a decade in Bollywood

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Jan. 10



Actress Rakul Preet Singh, who made her Hindi film debut in 2014 with romantic film 'Yaariyan' on Wednesday reflected upon her journey of 10 years in Bollywood, and said that it took hard work, perseverance, and consistency to reach where she is today.

After making her acting debut in 2009 in Kannada movie 'Gilli', Rakul Preet has featured in movies like 'Keratam', 'Yuvan', 'Puthagam', before making her Bollywood debut with 'Yaariyan', alongside Himansh Kohli. She played Saloni in the Divya Khosla Kumar directorial movie.

Now, on 10 years of the film's theatrical release, Rakul took to her Instagram, where she enjoys 23.5 million followers, and shared snippets from the movie 'Yaariyan'.

Along with the pictures, she penned a note, which read: "10 years ago, when I had first stepped in Bollywood, I was just a young girl with big dreams. It took me a decade of hard work, perseverance, consistency to reach where I am today."

"While there is so much more to achieve, I have a ton of gratitude in my heart for the work that I have done as it still feels like a dream for the younger version of me," shared the 'Runway 34' actress.

Some of her additional Hindi film ventures encompass 'Aiyaary,' 'De De Pyaar De,' 'Marjaavaan,' 'Doctor G,' 'Thank God,' and 'Chhatriwali,' among others.

Upcoming projects in her pipeline include 'Ayalaan,' 'Meri Patni Ka Remake,' and 'Indian 2.'

Meanwhile, rumours are swirling that Rakul is set to tie the knot with her long-term boyfriend Jackky Bhagnani in Goa in February this year.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Your energy is in the spotlight. Past ambitions could have wounded you in ways that forced you to miss out on typical experiences, leaving you unfamiliar with things others understand.

Taurus: Elders in your life are likely more than they seem. You may have had an incorrect concept of any older individuals you know -- and when they correct this image that you'd set in your mind, it could be shocking.

Gemini: You can heal friendships that were once wounded. It's possible that you or a close pal have been holding onto emotional injuries. No matter how difficult broaching the subject is, it's necessary.

Cancer: You may have to work with someone that you'd rather avoid. Regardless of past personality clashes, you'd be wise to release the differences that you've had before, in order to move forward with a clean slate.

Leo: You're able to be realistic about your routine. You might have been deluding yourself in the recent past, convincing yourself that you've been sticking to a positive habit that you're working toward, but unfortunately, this optimism may not align with reality.

Virgo: Thinking inside the box isn't going to get you anywhere fast. Problems could seem insurmountable when the official rulebook only offers one or two solutions, or maybe you're simply coming at the obstacle from the wrong angle.

Libra: Your squad can definitely hype you up! While you may not be the most extroverted person, you likely have good friends who want to boost your confidence when you're not feeling your best.

Scorpio: Realism is a virtue at the moment. You're capable of communicating in a more direct and honest way, rather than taking a roundabout path to explain yourself. On top of that, you may be ready.

Sagittarius: Stability can open unique windows for you at present. When you recognize a measure of personal security, you'll be able to protect yourself from potential consequences that would once have been too dangerous to risk.

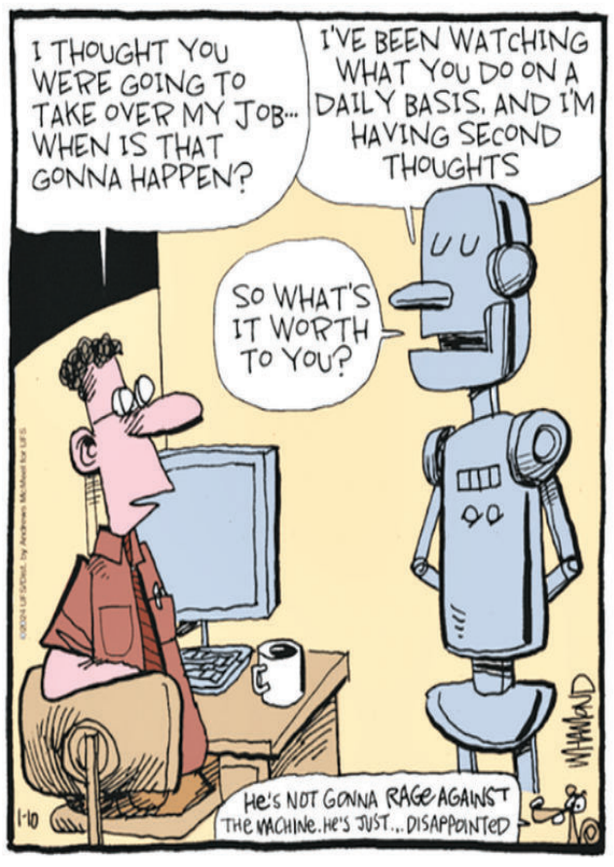
Capricorn: People may be looking to you to make imminent decisions. You could appear to have more presence of mind than those around you, so they might ask for advice regarding reaching a solution that everyone can be happy with.

Aquarius: You might now feel spiritual fulfillment, perhaps in a way that you didn't in a group of people. It's possible that a few hours spent alone after spending time with a large group will turn up your inner voice.

Pisces: Others should be treating you how they wish to be treated. At the moment, you may notice a group of loved ones who are proving that they care about your presence and the time and energy that you spend with them.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





CRICKETER LAMICHHANE SENTENCED TO JAIL FOR 8 YEARS



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

The Kathmandu District Court has sentenced cricketer Sandeep Lamichhane to eight years in prison after finding him guilty in a rape case.

The punishment was made public on Wednesday by the bench of Justice Shishirraj Dhakal.

The district court found Lamichhane guilty on December 29, 2023, but announced to make public the punishment on January 10, 2024.

According to the verdict, Lamichhane has been sentenced to eight years in prison under Section 219 3(E).

Likewise, Lamichhane needs to pay a fine of Rs. 300,000 and a compensation of Rs. 200,000 to the victim.

Meanwhile, Lamichhane's advocate said that the cricketer would knock on the doors of the High Court against the decision.

According to advocate Saroj Krishna Ghimire, Lamichhane still has the right to plead against the decision at a higher court. "We will reach the high court soon," he added.

Meanwhile, Kathmandu District Police Office informed that Lamichhane will not be arrested unless the deadline to appeal at a higher court ends. "If Lamichhane reached the higher court, we will follow the then orders," said Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Bhupendra Bahadur Khatri, chief of the district police.

The rape case was lodged against Lamichhane at the district court on October 31, 2022.

Middlesbrough stun Chelsea, take slender EFL Cup lead

AP
Middlesbrough, Jan. 10

Cole Palmer missed from close range and Chelsea lost 1-0 to second-tier Middlesbrough in the first leg of their League Cup semifinal on Tuesday.

Hayden Hackney scored in the 37th minute and Middlesbrough held on at Riverside Stadium against its Premier League opponent.

Mauricio Pochettino's expensively assembled team has been eyeing cup trophies to make up for a disappointing Premier League campaign. They'll have work to do in the second leg at Stamford Bridge on Jan. 23.

"We had too many chances to score where we didn't score. That is football," Pochettino told Sky Sports. "We have another 90 minutes at Stamford Bridge, and I think we need to be positive."

Middlesbrough hasn't been this far in the League Cup since winning the competition in 2004.

Hackney scored after sprinting past midfielder Moises Caicedo — a big-money signing last summer — inside the box and poking Isaiah Jones' low cross past goalkeeper Djordje Petrovic into the net.

"It was amazing. Great ball. I just got on the end of it," the 21-year-old Hackney said. "We said before the game — try to keep it tight and catch them on the counter."

Palmer, who shot wide earlier in the first half, just needed a tap in to equalize after Middlesbrough goalkeeper Tom Glover misplayed Enzo Fernandez's shot in the fourth minute of first-half stoppage time.

In what should have been a simple catch, the ball instead bounced off Glover's chest directly to Palmer, who tried to volley it in from about 5 yards out. He got under it, however, and his left-footed effort sailed over the crossbar.

The 21-year-old Palmer, who joined Chelsea from Manchester City for around $52 million in the offseason, is Chelsea's co-leading scorer this season with eight goals.

Middlesbrough is 12th in the Championship and lost to Aston Villa 1-0 on Saturday in the FA Cup third round.

"To beat a team of the quality of Chelsea, in any circumstances for us, is unbelievable," said Middlesbrough manager Michael Carrick, the former Manchester United star. "The lads were just exceptional. It was an incredible night."

Liverpool hosts Fulham on Wednesday in the other League Cup semifinal first leg.



PHOTO: AP
Chelsea's Axel Disasi, left, and Middlesbrough's Matt Crooks battle for the ball during the English League Cup semi final first leg in England.

Fiorentina reach Cup semis

Last year's runner-up Fiorentina reached the semifinals of the Italian Cup, but it again had to do it on penalties on Tuesday.

Maxime Lopez converted the decisive spot-kick as Fiorentina beat Bologna 5-4 on penalties after the match ended goalless in Florence — although the visitors hit the woodwork three times.

After a penalty masterclass from both teams, Stefan Posch blasted Bologna's final kick over the bar, giving Lopez the opportunity to secure Fiorentina's place in the final four for the third straight year.

Fiorentina, which needed penalties to beat second-division Parma in the round of 16, will face either AC Milan or Atalanta in the two-legged semifinals in April. Milan hosts Atalanta on Wednesday.

Bologna is enjoying a great season and knocked out two-time defending champion Inter Milan in the previous round.

It was sitting just a point below fourth-placed Fiorentina in Serie A, with both sides fighting hard for the Champions League qualifying spots.

Bologna had the better of the chances in Florence and should have taken the lead in the 34th minute but Joshua Zirkzee's effort came off the crossbar after some fancy footwork from the Dutch forward.

Riccardo Orsolini also hit the post for Bologna early in the second half, while Zirkzee saw another attempt palmed onto the left upright by Fiorentina goalkeeper Oliver Christensen in the third minute of extra time.

SNIPPETS

Jhiltung Cross Country Race on Jan. 20

Kathmandu (TRN): The eighth edition of the Jhiltung Cross Country Race has been scheduled for January 20, organisers informed on Wednesday. According to the organisers, Ward No. 5 of Belkotgadhi Rural Municipality, participants will compete on a 13.4-kilometre-long race track passing over different natural terrain. "The race will start from Kolputar in Ward No. 5 of Belkotgadhi and will pass through Belini, Chhap, Rajodar, Khadgachhap and Salchaur before returning to Kolputar," informed the organisers. "Of the 13.4km section, 4.5km will be uphill, 2km will be plain and the remaining will be downhill," said Madan Bhujel, ward chairman of Ward No. 5. Runners can compete in seven categories that include a 13.4km open race for male/female, 13.4km open for local men and a 13.4km open for veteran men. Likewise, there are four 4.5km 'run for fun race' segments. Organisers informed that national-level runners will be participating in the race.

CAN's GM appointment questioned

Kathmandu (TRN): The Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) announced Utsav Dhungana as its General Manager on Monday evening. Dhungana was selected from several candidates based on a written exam as well as an interview. However, candidates who were vying for the post have now raised questions over Dhungana's appointment. Nabaraj Koirala, one of the candidates for the post, organised a press in Kathmandu, on Wednesday and accused the appointment as biased. "The current manager might be an eligible candidate. However, the selection process was neither transparent nor trustworthy. Dhungana and CAN's secretary Paras Khadka are also a part of Baliyo Nepal, an organisation, so there are concerns over a conflict of interest as well," said Koirala. According to Koirala, he represented at least 12 candidates who applied for the General Manager post of CAN. "We give a 72-hour ultimatum to CAN to prove that the appointment was legitimate and unbiased. If not, we will reach the Supreme Court," said Koirala.

Green to play against WIndies

Sydney (AFP): Australian allrounder Cameron Green will start the first Test against the West Indies, selectors said Wednesday, but who replaces David Warner as opener remains to be seen. Warner bowed out of the five-day game at the weekend after the last Test against Pakistan in Sydney, having been a fixture at the top of the order for 12 years. Recognised openers Cameron Bancroft, Marcus Harris and Matt Renshaw were long seen as the main contenders to fill the role, until Steve Smith last week said he wanted to do the job. Renshaw was handed a Test lifeline as the only change in a 13-man squad for the two-Test series starting on January 17 in Adelaide, leaving Bancroft and Harris out in the cold. But chief selector George Bailey said Green, who has been forced out of the side in recent times by a resurgent Mitchell Marsh, would definitely play. That would either see him open the innings or more likely come in at four, where he usually plays for Western Australia.

Tottenham snap up Werner on loan

AFP
London, Jan. 10



Timo Werner returned to the Premier League on Tuesday after the German international joined Tottenham on loan for the rest of the season from RB Leipzig.

The 27-year-old struggled to shine during a two-year spell at Chelsea between 2020 and 2022 after a £45 million ($57 million) move.

Werner scored 23 times in 89 appearances but did help the Blues lift the Champions League in 2021.

However, his return for a second spell at Leipzig has also been far from a success as he fell down the pecking order under Marco Rose.

Spurs are in need of attacking reinforcements with captain Son Heung-min away at the Asian Cup for the next month.

Ivan Perisic, Manor Solomon and James Maddison are also sidelined by injury.

"A lot of things attracted me here," Werner told Tottenham's in-house media channels.

"First of all, the talk with the manager. I thought it was a really good talk. He gave me straight away the feeling that I need to join a club, what I want to feel when you talk to a manager and also the tactics and the style, how he wants to play, how he lets the team play.

"For me I thought straight away that it fits perfectly. Then the stadium, to play there every game is something special and also the team, I think we have some very good players. All of it was very interesting to me."

Werner has struck just twice in 14 appearances in all competitions this season. He could make his debut when Tottenham visit Manchester United on Sunday.

Spurs sit fifth in the Premier League, just one point outside the top four and six points off leaders Liverpool. Ange Postecoglou's men will also face holders Manchester City in the fourth round of the FA Cup later this month.

APF fix final date with Police in National Men's Volleyball

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Nepal APF Club and Nepal Police Club, two departmental teams, are facing each other in the finals of the 34th National Men's Volleyball Competition-2080 in Surkhet on Thursday.

APF and Police booked their places in the finals after defeating Gandaki and Tribhuvan Army in the semi-final matches on Wednesday. Title-defender APF, which has remained undefeated this season, outplayed Gandaki as it claimed victory in all three sets with resounding results of 25-23, 25-20 and 25-15. It was not an easy semis for APF.

On the other hand, Police also won all three sets against Army with great struggle. Army put up a great challenge as Police won the first two sets – 25-21 and 25-23 – with a small margin. The final set ended in 25-19.

The two finalists – APF and Police – were in the same group from the league-stage. Police lost against APF while facing in the 15th group match.

APF was able to secure three wins after playing four sets. The first two sets were in APF's favour as it ended 25-17 and 25-15; however, Police secured a win in the third set with the score 25-22. Nevertheless, APF won in the fourth set 25-20 to win the match.

While APF has remained dominant throughout the competition, winning in the finals will still be challenging with Police as its opponent.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:27 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.2	4.1	0.0
Dipayal	24.6	4.4	0.0
Dhangadi	13.1	10.8	0.0
Birendranagar	22.8	5.1	0.0
Nepalgunj	11.8	10.0	0.0
Jumla	17.0	-5.4	0.0
Ghorahi	22.2	8.2	0.0
Pokhara	21.1	8.7	0.0
Bhairahawa	16.6	11.5	0.0
Simara	14.3	10.5	0.0
Kathmandu	18.8	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.2	6.0	0.0
Taplejung	16.3	5.2	0.0
Dhankuta	21.8	7.8	0.0
Biratnagar	19.8	11.2	0.0
Jomsom	12.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	22.4	11.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.4	5.1	0.0*
Janakpur	16.0	9.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.7	-0.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 11, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.56	Rs. 133.16
Euro	1	Rs. 145.09	Rs. 145.74
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.62	Rs. 169.38
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.51	Rs. 156.22
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.86	Rs. 89.26
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.12	Rs. 99.57
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.58	Rs.100.03
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.14	Rs. 9.18
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.49	Rs. 18.57
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.52
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.78	Rs. 3.80
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.56	Rs. 28.69
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.04	Rs. 10.09
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.95	Rs. 13.01
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.45	Rs. 19.54
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.08	Rs. 433.03
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.62	Rs. 353.21

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Swiatek targets Australian Open glory as Osaka returns

AFP
Melbourne, Jan. 10



Iga Swiatek is in scintillating form as she seeks a maiden Australian Open crown, but she could face a stiff test from defending champion Aryna Sabalenka while two-time winner Naomi Osaka is making her comeback.

World number one Swiatek has won 17 of her 18 matches since she lost in the fourth round of her US Open title defence, going on to win the China Open and the WTA Finals.

The Pole has started the new season with a flourish, winning all five of her singles at the United Cup last week.

But the four-time Grand Slam champion knows Sabalenka, who last year became the first woman since Serena Williams in 2016 to reach at least the semi-finals of all four Grand Slams, is a huge threat.

The Belarusian overtook Swiatek for the top ranking in September and appeared on course to finish the year as number one until the Pole won the season-ending WTA Finals in Mexico to return to the summit.

The best previous result at Melbourne Park for Swiatek, 22, was reaching the semi-finals in 2022.

The 25-year-old Sabalenka was on a 15-match winning streak in Australia before Sunday's 6-0, 6-3 Brisbane International final defeat to Elena Rybakina in a rerun of last year's Australian Open championship match.

The 2022 Wimbledon champion Rybakina, ranked third in the world, will also be one of the favourites for the year's first Grand Slam, which will start on Sunday in a bid to reduce the amount of late-night finishes in the early rounds.

"We always push each other and I think that's great," said the Russian-born Kazakh, 24. "We improve this way, so hopefully we continue."

New mums return

Japan's Osaka and Germany's Angelique Kerber are among a number of mothers returning at the event after giving birth, a group that includes the 2018 winner, Caroline Wozniacki of Denmark.

Another recent mum, Ukrainian Elina Svitolina, is seeking to build on her impressive form after coming back in April last year.

She was in great touch in her Auckland warm-up last week, beating former Grand Slam champions Wozniacki and Emma Raducanu before losing a tight three-set final to American Coco Gauff.

Nineteen-year-old Gauff, who won her first major at the US Open in September, rounds out a powerful group of four at the top of the rankings.

Two-time Australian Open champion Osaka returned to the court last week after taking a 15-month break from the game, initially for mental health concerns. Last year she gave birth to daughter Shai.

The 26-year-old stayed upbeat after her second-round loss to Karolina Pliskova in Brisbane last week.

"I think for me even stepping on the court is a personal win because a couple of weeks ago I was even doubting if I could play with everyone," said Osaka. "I know that if I keep training and if I keep putting in the work, then I'll eventually get to where I want to be."

Wozniacki, 33, who reached the fourth round at last year's US Open, is playing at Melbourne Park for the first time since 2020, having had two children while away.

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